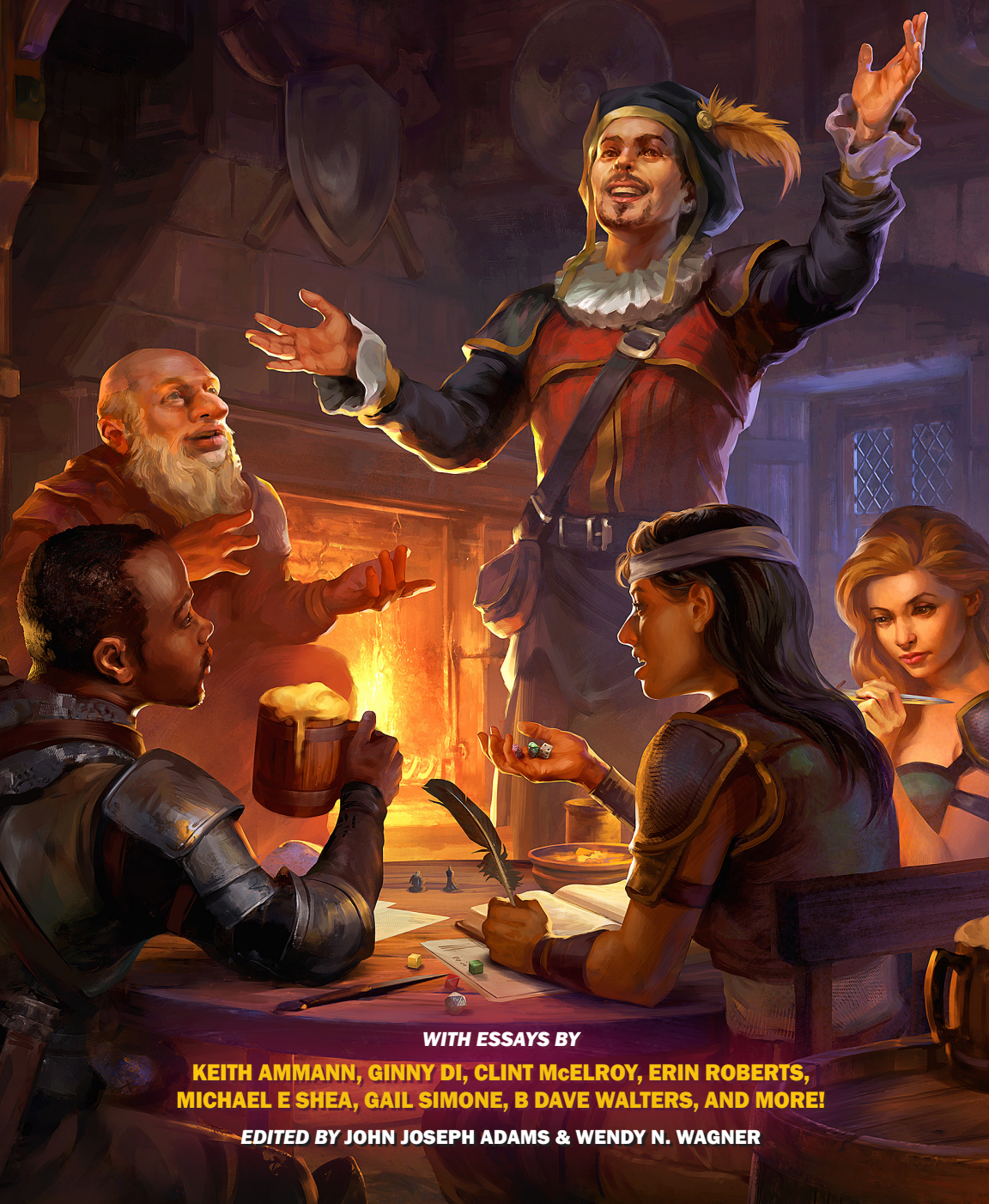


KOBOLD™ GUIDE TO ROLEPLAYING



WITH ESSAYS BY

**KEITH AMMANN, GINNY DI, CLINT McELROY, ERIN ROBERTS,
MICHAEL E SHEA, GAIL SIMONE, B DAVE WALTERS, AND MORE!**

EDITED BY JOHN JOSEPH ADAMS & WENDY N. WAGNER

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KOBOLD Guide to Roleplaying

Authors

Keith Ammann, Sharang Biswas,
Bryan Camp, Christopher M. Cevasco,
Curtis C. Chen, Ginny Di,
Shanna Germain, Basheer Ghouse,
Luke Gygas, Luke Hart, Shareef Jackson,
Rajan Khanna, Chris Kluwe, Scott Lynch,
Robert Mason, Clint McElroy, Erin
Roberts, Michael E. Shea, Gail Simone,
Sage Stafford, B. Dave Walters

Editors

John Joseph Adams & Wendy N. Wagner

Cover Artist

Egil Thompson

Graphic Design & Layout

Marc Radle

Additional Layout

Kennedy Williams

Publisher: Wolfgang Baur

Chief Operations Officer: T. Alexander
Stangroom

Director Of Digital Growth: Blaine McNutt

Art Director: Marc Radle

Editorial Director: Thomas M. Reid

Marketing Director: Chelsea "Dot" Steverson

Project Manager: Amber Seger

Community Manager: Zachery Newbill

Sales Manager: Kym Weiler

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Keith Ammann

Sharang Biswas

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Luke Gygax

Luke Hart

Shareef Jackson

Rajan Khanna

Chris Kluwe

Scott Lynch

Robert Mason (Bob World Builder)

Clint McElroy

Erin Roberts

Michael E. Shea

Gail Simone

Sage Stafford

B. Dave Walters

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction	11
<i>John Joseph Adams</i>	
Shamed Out, Loved In	13
<i>Gail Simone</i>	
Leaders, Liars, and Heartbreakers	17
<i>Ginny Di</i>	
Failure is Always an Option	22
<i>Bryan Camp</i>	
Rock & Role	27
<i>Erin Roberts</i>	
Beyond the Talky-Talky Bits	32
<i>Luke Hart</i>	
Preparation and Performance	36
<i>Chris Kluwe</i>	
All the Campaign World's a Stage	40
<i>Christopher M. Cevasco</i>	
Take Your Character on a Transformative Journey	45
<i>Sage Stafford</i>	
Genius, Not Omniscience	50
<i>Basheer Ghouse</i>	
Speak Friend and Enter	55
<i>Shanna Germain</i>	
Embrace the Embarrassment	60
<i>Shareef Jackson</i>	

Embodying the Dark Side	64
<i>Michael E. Shea</i>	
Power and Style	69
<i>Keith Ammann</i>	
RPGs are RPG if You RPG	75
<i>Clint McElroy</i>	
Stepping into Character	80
<i>Luke Gygax</i>	
The Hidden E in RPG	85
<i>Rajan Khanna</i>	
Yes, and . . . Now You're on Fire!	89
<i>Curtis C. Chen</i>	
Roleplaying "The Game Master"	93
<i>Sharang Biswas</i>	
From Monologue to Dialogue	98
<i>B. Dave Walters</i>	
Threading In	103
<i>Scott Lynch</i>	
Always Climb Onto the Dragon	109
<i>Robert Mason</i>	
About the Contributors.....	114

KOBOLD GUIDE TO ROLEPLAYING

INTRODUCTION

John Joseph Adams

Roleplaying. It's literally the name of the game. We all do it simply by playing, yet the word "roleplaying" vexes a great many players. What *is* it? How do I do it *well*? There are many definitions of roleplay in the essays that appear in this anthology (so I won't include another one here), but the very fact that so many of our authors felt the need to define it is one of the reasons this book exists: There are a lot of different ways to define and/or talk about roleplaying.

But here's the secret: Almost every aspect of an RPG is (or at least can be) roleplaying. Except, perhaps, for the actual rolling of dice—though even that can be used to further your roleplaying (as one of our essays tells us) if you allow your character's failures to drive your character growth. And the other secret is: You can't really *fail* at roleplaying . . . so long as you and the other people at your table are having fun.

In this anthology, you'll find twenty-one essays exploring every facet of roleplaying, from how to roleplay high charisma or intelligence to using character connections to deepen your roleplay. You should be able to find something to help you improve your roleplay, no matter what your table's like—or what roleplaying means to you.

So do your vocal warm-up exercises, re-read your backstory and character traits, consult the notes from last session, and let's get roleplaying!

SHAMED OUT, LOVED IN

Gail Simone

When I was a kid, we lived on a remote farm, far from the nearest town. It was a solid walk past a bunch of other farms to get to the bus stop, and there was no cable TV that far in the woods—so we had to make our own entertainment, like the hillbillies in all those horror films where someone takes a Wrong Turn and ends up a cannibal's buffet.

Of course, being a kid, I never got to pick the menu and so instead, the kids I knew (mostly my cousins and younger brother) would make up these elaborate adventures in the pastures and forest around the impossibly rural situation we found ourselves surrounded by, pretty much every chance we got.

The thing was, we had board games. We had a little bit of television reception—but mostly all we could watch was as much of all the boring old guys playing golf that we could stomach (which was very little indeed, as it turns out). We had animals to visit and bond with (but not *too* much, because, well, you've seen *Babe*, I'm sure).

And—thank the gods, we had books. So we had distractions. We had activities.

But nothing, nothing in the world, was as fun as play-acting action stories among the hay bales and crops. Batman was a favorite (I made my brother play the hostage, because I was terrible) as was Wonder Woman—plus various bionic characters—but there were also adventures in Narnia and Middle-Earth, and other fantastical realms.

And because kids don't know it's silly, we would become those characters. No costumes, sticks for swords, rocks for batarangs, it didn't matter. One kid was Robin, another was Bilbo, nothing made any sense, and it was the most fun I'd ever had. We'd be sent outside to find an activity, which meant getting out of the adults' hair, we'd groan and complain, and then once we started, we would play and fight and run until we got yelled at to come in for supper.

I feel genuinely bad for any kid with so many other distractions that they never got to do that. But that instinct, to be the hero of your own adventures, is something kids do naturally. No one *wants* to play the hostage; they want to be the hero. It's meaningful, it's enjoyable. It's affirming.

Above all, it's *liberating*.

I don't think we'd have enjoyed it much more if we did have proper costumes and props; that was never the point. The fun was, choreographing these elaborate set pieces and fight scenes and just being dorks in general, for the sheer, wild fun of it.

It leads to flights of whimsy, where a kid reads a book and imagines themselves in it. And that leads to a lifetime love of transportive fiction. The kid with the stick pretending to be Aragorn grows up to become the young person who writes fanfic, and maybe the adult who becomes a game designer, or an actor, or a novelist, or, god forbid and most shamefully, a comic book writer.

I work in a creative field and have been to conventions in forty-three countries. I can see the joy in the artist when someone loves their work, in the writer when a reader gushes over their story, in the cosplayer when someone is agog at their costume.

The point is, that feeling of play, of acting, of communal storytelling, that is one of the happiest times of our young lives. It connects us to a world of imagination where we are not merely witnesses, but participants. The person who engages the mind creatively and without regret gets to live not just one life, but many lives simultaneously. Their real one, *and* the vistas in their mind.

Where they are Batman, or Bilbo, or Wonder Woman.

But there's a brick wall on those tracks in almost all cases, something that breaks that chain from child-at-play to adult-with-dreams, and it comes in many forms: parents, teachers, even other kids.

At some point, someone says, "Quit acting like babies."

And Batman falls off the building, Bilbo gets eaten by wargs, Wonder Woman's invisible plane drops out of the sky.

Because imagination is fragile, it needs to be nurtured and protected from the elements. And someone, somewhere, maybe with good intentions (but often not), is going to tell you that play-acting is for babies, imagination is for losers.

Very little hurts like embarrassment when you're young and can't necessarily defend yourself or even explain why roleplaying is important, what a release it is. All you know is that scornful look and those adamant words: "Stop doing that, come in and do something useful."

Sometimes, roleplaying feels like a thing the whole world wants to tell you to stop.

Which makes carrying on a delightful defiance.

It's also the place where, as a kid, we are safe to attempt to imagine living another life. It's a vital empathy exercise and an expression of desires of the heart. At home, maybe you're unnoticed and unheard. But when you're roleplaying, you get to be whatever you truly want to be.

Break that chain, and maybe that kid grows up *not* to be the artist, the poet, the singer, the dancer. Maybe they go on to a fulfilling, productive life. But a part of them stays hidden forever, unshared and unknown.

Now, fast-forward. You get together with some people, maybe friends, maybe strangers, to play a roleplaying game. We've all done this, obviously, and we've all seen how new players hit a spectrum from *I'm all in* to *I'm going to be quiet for the entire evening*.

One new player grasps the idea instantly, lustily plays their character and loudly declares their every movement. But others—maybe remembering being yelled at the last time they tried playing someone else—instead shut down, finding the vibe an impossible train to catch.

I know that can be frustrating. I've seen players bullied by GMs and vice versa; it's fun for no one and very quickly has people looking for the door to escape. But please give a thought to this possibility, that some people have locked a bit of their ability to cut lose, to lose themselves in front of others, while playing being somebody else.

I say, bring those people in. Let them know it's a safe space, that there aren't any wrong moves, that they're not going to break rules they don't even know, and that it's just as fun to screw something up in the game as it is to nail it perfectly.

Let people make mistakes. Encourage them to participate by giving them encounters specific to them. When they pull away, gently show them the way back in.

We don't know their life. Maybe someone *really* cut their fantasy chain. Don't reinforce that; instead, be the wire tying it back together, from child-at-play to adult-with-dreams.

It's really my favorite thing to see in any session with new players, when the person that seems shyest and most baffled, suddenly yells, "I AM BATINA OF THE MOUNTAIN ELVES, AND THIS IS MY REALM!" and you realize, all at once—you've got another slayer on your hands. And isn't that just the best thing ever?

I had a relative like this. Popular, talented as a musician, but terribly afraid of being embarrassed, of saying the wrong thing, of standing out in a bad way. We played a game of D&D over a rainy holiday weekend, and everyone was excited to try, while my relative expressed only scorn and feigned disinterest.

Somewhere, inside, I am sure he was hearing that voice, *Stop doing this, dragons aren't real.*

But I knew he loved reading, loved adventure stories. So we started the group chained together in a dark prison, *Man-in-the-Iron-Mask*-style. Within minutes, he was struggling to find the key to the chains (unintentional symbolism alert). Within an hour, he was hooked (and unchained).

The next day, he was making dungeon maps. Within a week, he was running his own campaign, acting out the voices of every character.

It was and remains my favorite RPG experience ever, seeing his inner actor/storyteller/dramatist that I didn't even know existed. Because we gave him that platform, that way in, and made it as inviting as possible.

I guarantee you that you have people like that around you. Imagine how fun it will be to discover them in your proximity. Give them that chance, won't you?

Roleplaying is the multi-colored, life-enriching experience you have to be shamed out of loving . . .

. . . but that you can be loved into rediscovering.

Signed,

Batina of the Mountain People

LEADERS, LIARS, AND HEARTBREAKERS

A Player's Guide to Roleplaying Charisma

Ginny Di

Those of us who struggle to open pickle jars in real life usually don't think twice about kicking down a door in a roleplaying game. When we roleplay, our own body doesn't have any connection to our character's physical abilities—but when it comes to roleplaying a personality different from our own, that line blurs.

For game tables with an emphasis on social roleplay, it can feel like we're expected to demonstrate mental ability scores at the table. In particular, I often see people concerned about how to effectively play characters with high charisma when they don't consider themselves to be charismatic. Whether this is a result of TTRPG players being self-professed “socially-awkward nerds” or simply a matter of charisma itself being difficult to quantify and define, it seems to be the score that worries people the most. (Even roleplaying low charisma can be challenging to pull off without annoying your fellow players or turning into a caricature.) Thankfully, it is entirely possible to roleplay a character with high charisma without somehow transforming yourself into a real-life smooth talker.

Defining Charisma

Describing someone as charismatic in real life could mean a variety of different things, but luckily, when we're operating in the context of most RPGs, the term is more strictly defined. In D&D's *Player's Handbook*, for instance, charisma is described as, “your ability to interact effectively with others.” I like to return to this definition when in doubt, because

without it, it's easy to reduce charisma to simply "charm." But it's entirely possible to be effective in social situations without being agreeable—after all, deception and intimidation are also charisma-based skills. It might be more accurate to define charisma as "force of personality," an umbrella which includes both the positive forces of charm and persuasiveness, and the negative forces of being menacing or deceitful. After all, a beholder has 17 Charisma, and I suspect that most people who encounter them don't come away from that experience thinking, "What a charming creature!"

The *Player's Handbook* also explains that ability scores don't just represent someone's natural abilities but learned skills as well. This means that while having an innately magnetic personality or intimidating presence can certainly play a role in having high charisma, so can practiced eloquence and manners or experience with public speaking or performance. I think it's helpful to examine your character's high mental scores through both these lenses in order to get a well-rounded view of their personality. In what ways does your character display innate charisma, and in what ways have they learned charismatic skills?

Of course, scale cannot be ignored here. Returning to D&D as an example: an above-average Charisma score of 12 is going to look very different from a maxed-out score of 20, and while a score of 8 is certainly below average, that person is going to have a much easier time in social situations than someone with a score of 3. Instead of lumping all Charisma scores into "low" or "high," consider where your score falls on the full continuum. If 10 is an average person who can hold a conversation, make friends, and occasionally puts their foot in their mouth, then a score of 8 might mean they're a bit awkward, 5 might mean they struggle to hold a normal conversation, and 3 might mean they're almost universally disliked or misunderstood. Likewise, 12 might make them likable, 15 might make them popular, and 18 might mean they command a room the moment they enter it.

While what we've discussed above makes it pretty clear what charisma is, it's also important to recognize what it *isn't*. There's a pervasive belief among many RPG players that charisma correlates with physical attractiveness. This belief suggests that a high Charisma score makes a character beautiful or handsome—and a low Charisma makes them ugly. While First Edition D&D included an ability score called "Comeliness," which was modified by the character's Charisma score, later editions of the game do not include a character's looks in the definition of charisma—nor do any other games I can think of. I suspect we've all met people who didn't fit our conventional definitions of beauty but were nonetheless a force to be reckoned with in social situations, not to mention people whose good looks were wrapped around a miserable personality. While it's

perfectly reasonable to include a character's looks in your understanding of their charisma, I would caution you against relying on it as the foundation—and encourage you to ignore it completely if you don't find it interesting to explore.

High Charisma

Since we've already established that there isn't just one way to be charismatic, it's important to determine what kind of charisma your character has in order to know how to roleplay it. Your character could be seductive and magnetic, or disarming and likable, or intimidating and gruff—and each of these personality types would play out very differently at the table.

If you're unsure of how to narrow down your character's style, looking at their charisma-based proficiencies can be a good start. A character with proficiency in performance might be flamboyant and attention-getting, whereas a character with proficiency in intimidation might speak infrequently and instead communicate mainly in threateningly body language, significant looks, and loaded silences. Of course, you could just as easily have a performer who quietly draws the eyes of onlookers with the way they dress or carry themselves, or someone who intimidates by weaponizing their words to dismantle and challenge anything the other person says. Don't be afraid to challenge your assumptions about charisma. If you don't want to play a talkative character, or a flirtatious character, that's okay! That's the fun of it: There are many different ways that each charisma-based skill can be represented. As long as you're aware of the end goal, you can be creative with how you get there.

For example, let's say you want your character to be charming and likable. When interacting with NPCs or other player characters, this person might affirm their opinions and ideas, listen attentively when they talk, and laugh at their jokes. They might avoid doing and saying things that upset people, such as being rude, selfish, or boastful.

You can develop a list of "do's" and "don'ts" like this for any number of different personality types. An inspiring leader could be an attentive listener and take care to remind the group of their purpose and values when facing a difficult situation; they probably wouldn't be pessimistic, or express uncertainty or hesitance. A flirt could deliver compliments and touch people casually when interacting; they probably wouldn't wait for someone to approach them or be offended if someone showed romantic interest in them. An intimidating person could display unshakable confidence and feel comfortable making demands or threats; they probably wouldn't sugarcoat their words or apologize.

I think it's important to note that demonstrating high charisma in your roleplay does not necessarily demand an actual charismatic performance. Just like a player can say, "I climb the rocks" or, "I pick the lock," you can summarize or describe the things your character says, rather than saying every single word in character. Despite the oft-invoked false dichotomy of "roll-playing vs. roleplaying," there is a wide range of options between saying, "I seduce the barmaid" and giving a play-by-play of your entire courtship. You can provide some details of how you plan to gain the barmaid's affection while still summarizing your actions. Of course, every GM has different expectations for their table, but I generally find that the more detail the player gives, the more immersive the roleplaying experience can be for everyone at the table, and the more inclined the GM is to give your efforts a fighting chance. If a player says, "I seduce the barmaid," the roll required for success might be extremely high, whereas the more specific and nuanced, "I notice the barmaid reading behind the bar and ask her about the book, trying to strike up a flirtatious conversation, and then offer to buy her a drink" would be much easier to achieve.

If you're unsure of how to translate your character's charisma skill into first-person dialogue, don't be afraid to say things like, "she uses a commanding tone" or, "he gives an inspiring speech about the people in need of our help, the obstacles they've overcome already, and the past victories they've celebrated."

Low Charisma

Just as high charisma can come in many different flavors, so can low charisma. Ask yourself what personality traits make this character ineffective at social interaction. Are they impolite, never saying please and thank you, tracking mud into the pristine temple, and commenting loudly on the king's short stature? Are they shy, clamming up when speaking to NPCs, stuttering or sweating when addressed, and second-guessing all their thoughts and opinions? Are they haughty and dismissive of others, refusing to admit fault and acting arrogant and self-centered?

Unfortunately, since low charisma is directly tied to uncomfortable or unpleasant social interactions, it can be all too easy to slip into a persona that is annoying to your fellow players. Perhaps your table will find your rude, vulgar character funny—but there's also a good chance that they won't like it any more than the NPCs do. When in doubt, it's perfectly acceptable to talk with your group above-table to make sure you aren't crossing any lines that make the game less fun for everyone.

The Secret to Charisma

Are you ready for me to let you in on a secret? Pretty much anything that could demonstrate high charisma could also demonstrate low charisma. A person with high charisma could say flirtatious things that cause an NPC to fall head over heels for them. Meanwhile, a person with low charisma saying the exact same things could be perceived as inappropriate and/or as a creep. That's because charisma isn't just about what you *do*—it's also about how the things you do are *received*. For this reason, I think charisma is the skill that most demands communication and teamwork between a player and their GM. For example, if you play a charismatic character and you say something awkward, NPCs could see it as endearing. Once you determine the type of charisma you want your character to have, I highly recommend discussing it with your GM. If they know that your character has a threatening presence, for example, they can take that into account when playing off your character during social roleplay.

In the end, roleplaying means stepping into the perspective of someone who is different from us. You don't need to become a charismatic person in order to play a charismatic character, any more than you need to learn martial arts to play a monk. Pick a few character traits and habits that align with how you imagine your character would display charisma (or lack thereof), note them down somewhere you can reference them during sessions, and start playing that duplicitous bard or charming warlock!

FAILURE IS ALWAYS AN OPTION:

Using Failure to Drive Roleplay and Character Growth

Bryan Camp

Let your players be good at things. This is a ubiquitous truism among TTRPG game masters. While it is in fact good advice, it can be difficult for inexperienced GMs to see the difference between presenting a challenge to their players' abilities—which feels good to overcome—and stripping away those same abilities to turn a mundane task into a challenge—which feels limiting and (sometimes) like an unearned punishment.

The Narrative Benefits of Failure

One of the joys of TTRPGs is getting to inhabit the life and wield the abilities of a once-in-a-generation expert or a paragon of physicality when, in truth, most of us are merely average folks just trying to make it to the next game night. You should get to revel in the powers and talents your character possesses! You should get to be exceptional.

Problems can arise, though, when this generally useful advice becomes the foundation of a table's mindset, when the idea that characters should be allowed to be good at things stagnates into the belief that characters should *always* be good at things. That they should not, in essence, fail. There are game-mechanics challenges that arise from insisting upon success, but, more importantly, it can also become an impediment to good roleplaying. So much so that it is worthwhile to examine the flip side of the being-good-at-things coin if you're looking for a way to improve the roleplaying elements of your TTRPG experiences. As roleplayers, it is through success that we conclude an aspect of the plot, but it's in failure

that we enrich the *story*. And so, while it's human (and probably elf and dwarf) nature to always desire success over failure, as an experiment, try this out: Let your characters be bad at things. Don't just accept failure; embrace it. Seek it out. It's there that you'll find your way to your character's unique identity.

But wait—didn't you just say that the joy of TTRPGs is in rising above our mediocrity? Don't we play these games to be heroes? Heroes don't fail, they win. Right? Yes, yes, and yes—but we must not mistake the destination for the journey. Accomplishing your goals does not make you a hero, it merely makes you *successful*. True heroes don't just succeed, they succeed after striving through adversity, by falling again and again and always getting back up. True heroism is not being free of flaws, but in succeeding *despite* them. And so, if we want to find the heroes of our TTRPG stories, we must go searching for their flaws.

It's important to note that we're not talking about the sorts of flaws that you admit to in a job interview, where you describe something that is an overall strength as a weakness. If your "flaw" is along the lines of "I'm a perfectionist," "I can't leave a job unfinished," or "I'm almost too eager to learn new things" then you're not really grasping the concept. Nor am I suggesting an optimizer's version of embracing failure, where you dump the stats or skills or features that you plan for your character to use the least. What we're talking about is not the sort of thing you do once when you're conceptualizing your character and then avoid for the rest of the time you roleplay them: "Oh, I'm not even going to bother rolling for this because my character is so bad at it." Waiting until you have an opportunity to succeed is not the same thing as embracing the potential for failure. Instead, try focusing in on those moments that, as players, we instinctively tend to try to leave behind.

Failure: A Case Study

Let's consider a specific example. One of the characters I've played the longest is a very observant, very intuitive character, and I try to lean into that whenever I can. He's also a living machine in a world where most sentient beings are made of flesh, which said to me at the point of creating the character that, logically, he would be inclined to misunderstand some things that a breathing creature would simply know. I didn't decide he'd be bad at intuition, rather that he would intuit very confidently and very incorrectly some aspects of non-machine-life interactions. At one point early on in our adventures, he saw a human give another human a single coin at the end of a very brief interaction, a gesture that any human observer recognizes as "giving a tip," with all the social and economic baggage associated with it.

Later, in an interaction between my machine-person and a human, I attempted to observe some detail about our interaction, and—since we were early enough in our adventures that failing at this kind of attempt was still possible for that character—the math did not work out in my favor. I did not discern the lie or catch the code word or whatever momentary goal I was trying to achieve. I failed. But I didn't let that be the end of it. I didn't say, "I failed my check, somebody cast a truth spell." Instead, I embraced the moment and thought, "Well, what mistake would he make here?" And my mind went back to the tip, and I had my character reach into his pocket and pull out a silver coin.

I honestly couldn't tell you if that interaction was with an antagonist that we ended up fighting or if it was some benign lore dump with a trusted ally or if we never saw that NPC again. What matters is not the dice roll that I failed, nor the goal that we eventually accomplished. What matters is that I took that moment of failure and, by embracing it as a moment for my character, turned it into a trait that followed him for literal years of gameplay. He gave silver coins to queens and monsters and orphans in the street, (almost never appropriately to either station or social situation) and held out his hand in expectation at times as well. It wasn't a huge thing—a quirk, mostly—but it helped me understand the character. It was a piece of him that helped me return to his voice and mannerisms and beliefs and fears whenever it was time to return to that table. Then, recently, after a tense standoff with a long-term antagonist, my character turned to leave and, dismissively, dropped a single copper piece. It's one of my favorite little moments from roleplaying that character, and it grew out of embracing a moment where I failed when I should have succeeded.

A Balance that Binds the Game Together

While good roleplaying can be found in embracing failure, it's important to pursue a balanced approach, not a complete abandonment of the goals your character might strive toward. You should make an honest appraisal of your character's weaknesses and flaws, anticipate the ways in which they might fail, and then use those moments as opportunities for enrichment. You shouldn't actively try to cause things to go poorly just to watch things crumble. There's a difference between working to build a sandcastle even though the tide is coming in and kicking over the sandcastle someone else built just to see how they react.

Failure for GMs

Embracing failure as a method of improving roleplaying and narrative isn't just for players; it's a philosophy that can benefit a GM's ability to embody their own characters and also heighten their overall storytelling prowess. For some GMs, since our characters are either allies or antagonists to the focus of our story, our characters' relationship to failure falls into one of two categories. Either the character is comic relief (fails often, fails publicly, and fails *hard*) or they are a serious character (whether an actually useful ally or a genuine threat) and thus are largely impervious to failure.

That makes sense, to an extent. As a player, you wouldn't want to find out that the wise mage you were told could answer all your questions turned out to be a fraud, nor would you want to discover, after defeating the powerful and manipulative enemy that you've struggled against the whole campaign, that they actually had an inherently flawed evil plan that never would have worked, even if you'd done nothing. These aren't the sorts of GM-character failures we're talking about. However, the old adage, "Everyone is the hero of their own narrative," is relevant here. Your antagonists and allies should also be defined by their struggles against opposing forces.

Your archetypal characters—wise old mages, clever crime bosses, discerning investigators, evil overlords, and so on—don't need to be failures, they just need to *experience* failure. Nor does it have to happen at the hands of your players, or even in front of them. Give them setbacks. Give them thwarted ambitions. Give them moments of loss that still haunt them. Consider the ways in which your archetypal ally or villain has failed in their journey to where they are when the players meet them, and you will find that they have become less of an archetype and more of a unique character. To paraphrase a line from Tolstoy, "Every powerful mage rose to power in the same way, but their failures along the way were their own."

The Opportunities Behind Locked Doors

Looking beyond a GM's characters, it can also benefit the overall culture of the table if the GM embraces failure as a philosophy. Allow your characters to fail forward, rather than backward. Frustrations over something that seemed to "go wrong" in a game tend to stem from a moment where an interaction or encounter was reduced to a success/failure binary.

As an example, let's take a staple of TTRPG obstacles: the locked door. Generally speaking, this is the simplest of interactions in a game. You've got a pathway forward, you've got an impediment to that path, you've got a character who is sneaky and good at getting past locks, they roll and get to be good at something. Success-based thinking says that if they fail at this,

well, too bad. Sometimes locks are beyond your talents. Sometimes you have a bad day. Sometimes you're just unlucky. Accept your bad dice roll and move on.

And that's perfectly fine sometimes! Sometimes we just fail. But we must acknowledge that this is not the sort of failure that allows our player the opportunity for roleplaying. It's not a defeat, it's merely a denial of success. Nor does it actually keep the players from achieving their goal. The strong character can bash in the door. The magic character can magic it open. The clever character can trick a guard into giving them the key.

So if the bad roll to unlock the door won't do anything for the lock-picking character, and it won't actually stop the group from moving forward, why not let it be a more interesting forward-moving sort of failure? Rather than simply failing to unlock the door, make it take longer than usual, so long, in fact, that the guard patrol is now just around the corner. Or they manage to bypass the lock, but not the silent alarm that now gives the group a ticking clock that didn't exist before. Don't make failure stop progress, make it drive narrative.

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Ultimately, this concept is the same for players and GMs alike. Let your characters be good at things, but pay attention to those moments when they're not, and then make those moments *matter*. That's where you'll find the experiences that make a character unique.

ROCK & ROLE:

How Karaoke Can Make You a Better Roleplayer

Erin Roberts

I can't remember the very first time I roleplayed at a TTRPG table, but I expect that it went something like this—my hands were sweaty, my mouth was dry, and I felt like everyone was staring at me, waiting for me to fall flat on my face. Exactly like my first time singing karaoke.

On the one hand, roleplaying and karaoke don't seem to have too much in common—one is an opportunity to tell a collaborative story and the other is generally a performance in front of a crowd. And yet there are commonalities. Both can give you a sense of community. Both are done in front of an audience (even if it's only your friends). And both can be absolutely terrifying.

Luckily, I've been to karaoke more times than I can count, and I've picked up a few techniques in front of the microphone that work equally well when rolling dice. Whether or not you ever decide to take the stage, I hope these tips help you out as you roleplay your heart out around the gaming table.

1 Remember that Everyone Wants You to Succeed

One of the most important things to remember when you begin roleplaying is this—the other people at your table or in your audience want to have a good time as much as you want them to. Just as it is more fun for the patrons of a karaoke spot when the person at the microphone is rocking out, it's more fun for your fellow players if your roleplaying

goes smoothly. That means they'll generally be cheering you on, often in very tangible and noticeable ways. Even in your earliest attempts, you'll find people giving you the benefit of the doubt during awkward moments, rooting for you to triumph over any small missteps, and encouraging you when things are going well. So, as you begin to implement some of the pieces of advice below, start with this one: Take a deep breath and do your best—we're all here for you!

2 Get Excited for the Good Parts

One tangible way to bring genuine enthusiasm and fun to your table is to remember what you love about the characters you're roleplaying. Just as getting to the chorus of a popular song might be the part that carries you through the verses, anticipating the fun parts of the roleplaying experience that are around the corner can help you stay excited even during scenes that you don't feel as comfortable with or are less naturally excited about.

So remember to feel the love. You can start by coming up with a sentence or two that captures the characters' general vibe as you might describe them to someone else. What gets you the most jazzed up or feels the most relatable? Is it their attitude towards life? The unique background they bring to the table? The terrible secret they are hiding from everyone around them? Ultimately, what's important in this exercise is what matters to you—three different people might find the same character intriguing for different reasons, like three different performers bringing their own unique takes to the same song.

Once you know what excites you about the character, keep it in the front of your mind, even if it isn't immediately relevant. You can even jot down what you're looking forward to somewhere on your character sheet or prep documents. This can help you keep it in mind if you're switching back and forth between NPCs or find that you lose touch with the characters you're roleplaying as you get into the heart of the session. As a bonus, if you're a player in a game with a GM who is okay with it, let them know about the aspects of your character that you want a chance to lean into. They may be able to create situations that really let you shine.

3 Give Yourself an Easy Win

A market's offerings are rarely provided without the presence of vendors. One of the first questions asked of anyone who sings karaoke is, "What's your go-to song?" Often, this isn't the most complicated song out there—instead, it's one that the singer enjoys, can pull off well, and is popular enough to make other people sing along. The roleplaying version of this is go-to character traits—simple and clear elements of character that help get you into the roleplaying spirit. These should generally be easy to remember, work well in a variety of situations, and be low-key enough not to stop a session in its tracks (and should also absolutely avoid using stereotypes or mockery rooted in real-world people or identities). They could include:

A word, phrase, or speech pattern that the character often uses, like Yoda's habit of putting the object before the subject and verb (speak, he does).

A belief or area of interest that shapes the way the character views the world, like the Klingon habit of relating everything back to honor.

A habit that the character often falls back on or trait that they often express, like the tendency to flip a coin before every decision or a fascination with the colors of others' shoes.

An article of clothing or accessory that makes you feel like you can more fully embody the character, like a superhero's costume or a signature look.

If the character is a regular, feel free to find a few of these. For one-off NPCs, try coming up with one or two that help you quickly get into the character's mindset. Ideally, these line up well with what excites you about each character, helping you to take their broader traits or goals and pair them with compelling attributes, quirks, and details. These are great to incorporate early in a session as you get into character but can also be used to ground yourself at any time if you start to lose faith in the way that you are bringing a specific character to life.

One note of caution: Any go-to song can become *a lot* if sung seven times a night, so don't overdo it. Try making some of your go-tos broader ideas that you can adapt to different situations or try creating a longer list so that you have some variety. The former can be very powerful—I remember being at a table with a player who gave their character a love of nature and flowers that impacted everything from the ways their spells looked to the foods they gravitated toward. Since each instance was a little different, it never felt overused. The most important thing, though, is to find the go-tos that work for you. Try them out! Experiment! Enjoy!

4 Lean into Who You Are and What You're Trying to Do

While it's important to be flexible when roleplaying, it's also good to ground yourself in who you are and what your particular session calls for. In karaoke, I call this leaning into the singer and the song—learning both what works well for you and how to best take advantage of the mood of the moment.

“Leaning into the singer” is all about knowing yourself. As you start roleplaying, you may find that you hit on something that you really enjoy doing. Maybe it's a specific voice quality or tone (a whispered snarl or a high-pitched musical way of speaking). Maybe it's a specific type of language (gruffly giving orders or cheekily bantering your way into getting information). Generally, though, it should be something that transcends any specific character, the way that a singer's raspy voice might show up in many different songs. When you find something like this that works for you, remember it and look for places where it makes sense to use it from one character, session, or table to the next. If nothing else, it should make your roleplaying experience more fun.

To “lean into the song,” be aware of the feel of the roleplaying moment that you are in. Much as a singer would change their vocal style when moving from an R&B slow jam to a Broadway ballad, you may want to change your roleplaying approach from one campaign or session to the next, especially as you react and respond to the actions of other players. Are you in the middle of an epic fight scene? Your roleplaying may be restricted to the way you make strategic decisions during the ebb and flow of battle. At a tavern getting information from a friendly local? Your roleplaying can be more in-depth and might draw from your character's history or past accomplishments.

You may also want to think about the emotions of the scene that you're in. What song might be playing if a movie were made of this moment? A battle to avenge a fallen friend, for example, might have more stirring speeches than a standard clash. A local jester sharing information at the tavern might offer more quick-witted banter than a sullen barkeep. Often, tone can change as you gain information, make decisions, or switch locations. Being aware of it helps to keep your roleplaying efforts in alignment with everyone else at your table.

5 Have Fun

While it is always fun to listen to someone belt out a Whitney Houston or Celine Dion track as if they were auditioning for the next spot on *The Voice*, most folks save their loudest and longest applause for the person who seems like they are having the most fun. Much in the way that yawning makes other people yawn and laughter is contagious, being passionate and committing to what you are doing tends to make people lean in and want to support you, whether or not you give the same kind of polished performance as someone who does this for a living.

The trick to generating that kind of passion, commitment, and enthusiasm? Enjoying yourself. While it may be easier said than done, if you can go with the moment as you roleplay and find enjoyment in it, you'll often carry folks with you no matter what is going on. The tools and ideas listed above can help your roleplaying, but they are no substitute for trusting your gut and having a great time.

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And there you have it. Well, *almost*; my final tip as you take these techniques from the stage to the table is this: **(6) Be the Audience For Everyone Else That You Would Want For Yourself.** Be the person leaning in and hoping that your fellow players succeed. Enjoy the things that excite them. Celebrate their wins. Help them capture the mood. The best nights, whether in a karaoke spot or playing your favorite TTRPG, are the ones where everyone leaves having had a phenomenal time.

BEYOND THE TALKY-TALKY BITS:

Roleplaying Outside of Social Interactions

Luke Hart

When we hear the commonly uttered phrase, “I really like the roleplaying aspect of the game,” almost all of us know exactly what the person means by “roleplaying”: the parts of the game where their character is talking in-character with other characters or NPCs, often using special voices or accents (though not necessarily). I personally refer to this as the “talky-talky” bits of the game . . . and you’ll see why in a moment.

But there’s a problem here: Almost everyone uses the word “roleplaying” *incorrectly*.

Why? Because the entire game is roleplaying! What most people refer to as roleplaying—the talky-talky bits—is only *one aspect* of roleplaying. The fact is: There is so much more to roleplaying in RPGs than just talking in-character.

Defining Roleplaying

At its heart, roleplaying is putting yourself in the shoes of another person and saying and doing the things that person would. In RPGs, if you're the player, we call these other persons "PCs," and if you're the GM, "NPCs". (And for the record, even monsters that solely exist for the sake of slaughtering are NPCs, too.)

So if you're a player roleplaying your PC, your task is to say and do what your character would say and do. Many times, what *your character* would say and do in a given situation is very much different than what you would say and do. This is why it's called roleplaying! And, yes, it's very much like acting—only without the paycheck.

Thus, if you are a dwarven fighter named "Krug the Kruel" negotiating with a shopkeeper, your task is to ask yourself what Krug would say and do, and then have Krug say and do it. Would Krug politely ask the shopkeeper for a discount? No, of course not! *You* might, but you're roleplaying Krug, not yourself. No, Krug would lean over the counter, clench his fist, flex his massive arm, and demand—in a Scottish accent, of course—that the shopkeeper knock 10% off . . . or else.

At this point, I suspect that most readers are with me and agree that our example of Krug is indeed roleplaying. And, of course, it is. But do you see what I did?

Our example didn't just involve Krug talking to the shopkeeper, he was also using intimidating gestures—getting closer, clenching his fist, flexing his arm—to aid in the attempt to coerce the shopkeeper. You see, Krug was engaged in *action*, not just *conversation*. And that begins to get us much closer to understanding the true nature of roleplaying.

Another example will probably help, and let's use Krug again—not because I'm a lazy writer but because I like dwarves (and Scottish accents).

This time Krug is in a deep, dark, dank dungeon. He kicks open a door and stumbles upon a group of four kobolds. The creatures are terrified by this axe-wielding monstrosity and promptly offer a pot of shinies to be spared squishing. Now, Krug's companions—a wussy elf, tender-hearted cleric, and do-gooder paladin—are inclined to accept the offer and move on. However, Krug's village was attacked by a dragon and its kobold cronies when he was younger, and the sour old dwarf has borne a thirst for vengeance ever since. Therefore, bribes and negotiation simply aren't on the table for Krug; he raises his axe, screams a battle cry, and charges.

And *that* is just as much roleplaying as speaking with a shopkeeper in a Scottish accent. Not a word was spoken, and yet there were heaps upon heaps of roleplaying going on in that scenario.

On the Three Pillars

Perhaps you've heard about "the three pillars" of roleplaying games. They are commonly brought up in the context of game design, as incorporating and balancing said three pillars improves the enjoyability of a game for both players and game master. However, it also suits our purpose to pull them into the context of roleplaying because the three pillars help us better understand what roleplaying is to create.

- **Combat.** We know what this is. Axe to face, fireballs in crowded areas, a well-timed stab in the back—for most RPG players combat is part and parcel, as ubiquitous as dwarves and Scottish accents.
- **Exploration.** This pillar is often misunderstood as simply being overland travel, going from point A to point B where the former is often a city and the latter the location of the deep, dark, dank dungeon. However, exploration is also poking around said dungeon, inspecting the doors for traps, checking the chest for a false bottom, solving the puzzle that blocks the way forward, and the like.
- **Social Interaction.** And this here is our baby. When most people say "roleplaying" what they are *actually* referring to is the social interaction pillar of gameplay. Social interaction involves the talky-talky bits: conversations with shopkeepers, negotiations with acid-spitting dragons, and the like.

So what's my point? *Every single one of the three pillars is roleplaying!*

When Krug charges the kobolds and lays axe to face, you are roleplaying Krug.

When Krug kicks down the door and smashes the chest to bits just in case there is a false bottom—there wasn't, but breaking things makes Krug happy, so it's okay—you are roleplaying Krug.

When Krug threatens to wring the shopkeeper's neck if he doesn't give them a discount, you are roleplaying Krug.

Every single aspect of an RPG can be classified as one of the three pillars, and whenever you as a player or game master engage in any of them, you are roleplaying. The act of roleplaying permeates every nook and corner of an RPG; you simply cannot escape it. And it shouldn't surprise us. They are, after all, called *roleplaying games*.

If in-character conversations were the only aspect that was actually roleplaying, we wouldn't call them roleplaying games. Instead, they'd be called social interaction games, or—I'd like to hope—talky-talky games. But they aren't; thus, roleplaying encompasses the totality of the game, all three pillars.

Where Do We Go from Here?

If my powers of persuasion haven't failed me—and if they have, I'll send Krug to negotiate on my behalf—you will perhaps agree that although talking in-character is roleplaying, it is only but a *part* of roleplaying.

It is thus that I call upon you to join me with thousands of other players and game masters who are taking up our pitchforks, lighting our torches, and converging upon musty basements, game shops, and anywhere else players and GMs gather, in order to convince them by diplomacy, intimidation, or force of arms to immediately cease this erroneous use of the term *roleplaying*.

Okay, that was a long sentence and it was written in jest . . . mostly.

Instead, my call to action is a bit simpler, less likely to land you in legal trouble, and something that perhaps comes a bit more naturally to us gamers. The next time you're in an RPG and you witness the sacrilege of using *roleplaying* to refer to *social* interaction, I urge you to speak up. Refuse to sit silently as the name of roleplaying is profaned. Rather, respond as many of us are wont to respond in such disputes, with the renowned and much acclaimed: "Um . . . actually . . ."

Of course, if you're not keen on being *that guy*, you might also gift the offending person with a copy of this book—with this essay bookmarked and with key passages highlighted, naturally.

At the end of the day, you're reading a book on roleplaying, a *Kobold Guide to Roleplaying*, and what better way to put into practice what you're learning than to exercise the qualities we all love most about kobolds: their clever, tricky nature, their propensity to spread chaos, and their ability to steal away what we love most—such as the time-honored tradition of using the word *roleplaying* inaccurately.

PREPARATION AND PERFORMANCE:

How to Be a Bard at the Table Even if You're Playing Something Else

Chris Kluwe

Hello everyone, and welcome to the show! “What is the show,” you ask? Why, it’s the show you want to put on at your next gaming session, to wow your friends with clever quips and thrilling acts of friendship (and maybe even some light betrayal) as you continue your adventures in whatever world you’re currently exploring. It’s the show you, as a player, want to create as your character, and central to that show is the ancient art of “roleplaying,” (or, as some might call it, “acting,” or even “being a dramatic attention hog, can’t you just be quiet for half a minute, Chris?”).

However, sometimes that stage can be a bit daunting, so I’m going to try and offer you some tips and tricks to help you make the most of your roleplaying endeavors.

One of the best things about roleplaying games is that they offer players (and GMs) the opportunity to roleplay as someone completely different from who they actually are—a spotlight star on a grand stage of magic and mystery. From a theoretical standpoint, the idea of roleplaying your character often feels full of excitement and potential, a chance to escape from the boring mundanity of normal life, but it can quickly devolve into a maze of conflicting emotions: “Am I being consistent in my motivations?” “Does this voice make me sound silly?” “How would my character actually respond in this situation?” etc.

Suddenly, the excitement of roleplaying is gone, weighed down by the worry that the role isn't "right," or that you might get caught having to respond to something with no clear answer as to how you should behave. You fear that you might be embarrassing or that you're disrupting the narrative flow, and now, instead of a joyous, adventure-filled get-together with friends, it's an awkward dice-rolling session around a table with the occasional muttered cough as someone reaches for the snacks.

Fortunately, there is a way to ensure your roleplaying comes off smoothly more often than not, and it involves two key concepts: preparation and performance.

In my career as a professional athlete—<record scratch> yes, I am going to tie sports and RPGs together—the key indicator for how well I played is how prepared I was before the game. Now, for me, preparation involved mastering lots of silly little technical details—such as “Is my drop happening at the right time?” “Are my steps the proper length?” and “Am I keeping my hips square and my body weight forward during my follow-through?”—but the core concept is the same in football as it is in roleplaying a character in an RPG: In order to do something well, you have to spend time *beforehand* making sure all those silly little technical details are sound so you don't have to think about them when it comes time to perform.

From a roleplaying perspective, this means your character's backstory is important, and you being able to envision that backstory as your *own background* is even more important because that's what will allow you to react fluidly and naturally to situations as they develop. If you want to roleplay memorably, before you even set foot in your gaming session, you have to spend time creating that backstory, memorizing it, and then having conversations with yourself on what that actually means in how you see the world.

As an example, let's say I want to play Lark, a thief from a large city. The first silly little technical detail I need to master is, “Why am I a thief?” Do I steal because it's the only way I can feed myself? As an act of social rebellion? Because I'm addicted to the rush? Understanding *why* your character wants to do something is the first step in presenting yourself to others as that character, and your class (or archetype or profession etc.) in an RPG goes a long way toward defining what your character finds important. Picking a class isn't just about the powers and abilities it offers (though those are indeed very cool and a big part of it), it's also about what that says about your character as a person.

The second silly little technical detail I then need to know is, “Where am I from?” Was Lark born in poverty? The child of a well-off and overprotective merchant? The last scion of a disgraced noble family? This

is the environment that defines your character's social interactions growing up, and how they interact with various groups and socioeconomic castes. Lark the orphan urchin pickpocket is going to speak much differently to a city guard than Lark of House Darkwater, dashing corsair of the shadows. Being able to envision how your character would converse with people will help you actually converse with those people when it happens in game (which seems obvious on the surface, but so many necessary skills aren't obvious until you stop to really think about them).

The third thing to master is, "Where am I going?" What are my overarching goals as a person, my drives and motivations? Is it to make sure I never go hungry again, along with those I grew up with? To upend the corrupt economic system I find myself trapped in? To regain the status and glory of my ancestors, and then surpass them? Knowing where your character wants to go allows you to figure out your natural response to situations that arise during the adventure, because it either helps advance your goals in some way or it doesn't, and then you can react accordingly (again, obvious, but if you don't take the time to think about it beforehand, you won't know the answer).

These three things are the fundamentals of your preparation, and mastering them will give you the foundation you need to actually perform when the game session begins. Now, let's talk about the actual performance.

Performing well in front of people, whether it be an entire stadium filled with tens of thousands, or your group of friends around a table, is all about not having to think. You need to be entirely present in the moment, not thinking about anything else, so you can react with speed and focus to whatever comes up. This is why preparation is so important, because without preparation, when it comes time to perform, your focus will be on *thinking about* what the correct response should be, rather than simply *doing* that response.

In addition, being entirely present in the moment also means you're not worried about what you look like, how you sound, or whether or not those tight pants make your butt look big as other men rush over to try and give you violent hugs (what can I say, football is a very silly sport). Being entirely present means you are *committed* to what you're doing right there and then; that it's the only thing that matters to you in that particular instant, and that all of your focus is on executing that one particular task.

See, a good performance isn't a singular event that magically happens, whether it be football, D&D, or anything else. It's something that you've practiced again and again through your preparation, an outcome that you've worked at and envisioned to achieve your desired results. Some people may *initially* be more naturally gifted in specific areas, whether it be athletic or oratory, but they'll never be as successful as those who've put in the preparation. All it takes is time and effort.

Finally, I want to finish up with the following advice (which applies to both football, RPGs, and pretty much everything else in life): Everyone makes mistakes, and don't forget to have fun. I was one of the best in the world at what I did (kicking a football high in the air, which is a proficiency so specialized you won't even find it in the addendums to the *Player's Handbook*) and despite all my preparation and practice, even I made mistakes from time to time (generally in front of a live audience of millions of people). If you forget some crucial bit of backstory or get tongue-tied during what's supposed to be a dramatic moment, try your best to let it go, because if you keep worrying on something in the past, you're no longer present in the moment, and it's much more likely you're going to make another mistake. Every successful person I've played with has made mistakes, but they've also had the capacity to learn from those mistakes and not let them linger. You're never going to get to reroll those dice, so just accept the result and move on.

As for having fun: That one's pretty self-explanatory. Don't get so caught up in trying to make your performance perfect that you lose sight of the goal of RPGs: Having fun with your friends. At the end of the day, roleplaying your character should be something you find enjoyment in, and if everything I've just gone over seems like too much work, then simply don't do it. The tips I've laid out here regarding preparation and performance may not be for everyone, and that's okay.

After all, there's no "correct" way to have fun, unless you're being controlled by mind flayers (in which case there very definitely is a "correct" way to have fun, and it involves them slurping out your brains like a smoothie).

Good luck on those Wisdom saves, and may your sessions be filled with natural 20s!

ALL THE CAMPAIGN WORLD'S A STAGE:

Roleplaying as Worldbuilding

Christopher M. Cevasco

When a GM and group of players gather to take part in an RPG campaign, they're playing a game. But unlike with many other types of games, they're also engaging in an act of collaborative storytelling. An experienced and prepared GM will make sure the outline or skeleton of the story is already there before the first roll of the dice, but it is up to both the GM and the players to put flesh on that skeleton and breathe life into it through their choices and character actions and interactions throughout the game.

Active vs. Passive Roleplaying

Notwithstanding the fact that the term roleplaying gives rise to the first two letters—RP—of the very acronym that describes this type of game, there is not strictly speaking a *requirement* that the players or the GM step into and inhabit their characters through active roleplaying. The campaign can be played solely by relying on the game's mechanics; character interactions, dialogue, and emotions can simply be described in third person. Consider each of the following:

GM: A frightened halfling steps through the gate and begs you for help. His family has just been abducted by orcs.

GM: The townswoman looks around nervously and is reluctant to speak with you.

In each instance, the GM gets across the relevant information, and players can respond in any number of ways. But consider instead these alternate approaches:

GM: A frightened halfling steps through the gate. “Help! They’ve come again! My family . . . [gasping sobs] I don’t know where they are. There’s blood in the streets! Orcs! They’re back. . . . Please help me!”

GM: The townswoman glances over a shoulder. “Not here. There are ears everywhere! The peace guards have ways of hearing us! If one of my neighbors sees me talking to you, and it gets back to them, it’ll mean my death at the Hanging Oak.”

By stepping into the halfling and townswoman roles in this way, the GM not only dramatically increases the tension of each moment, but also subtly adds to the picture the players have of the campaign world. In one world, orcs seem to be raiding this region with some regularity, and those raids are palpably chaotic and violent. The other world is one in which common folk can’t trust their own neighbors, in which an oppressive regime brutally enforces its laws through a police force with the ironic name of “peace guards,” and perhaps most disconcerting of all, there is a nearby tree colloquially known as the Hanging Oak. In each case, the GM’s roleplaying has given the players crucial bits of information—information that is likely to dramatically influence the ways in which the players choose to have their characters respond.

But worldbuilding through roleplaying is not something only the GM should be expected to do. Again, RPG worldbuilding is a collaborative effort, and when players inhabit their characters, they too can help flesh out the skeleton the GM provides. Consider the following player contributions:

Player 1: Mork the Mighty swears to aid the forest folk in recovering their lost treasure.

Player 2: I’d like to visit the tavern and order a round of drinks to toast the empress.

These are perfectly acceptable ways for players to describe what their characters want to do. On the other hand, the very same players might convey the same information via roleplaying as follows:

Player 1: Mork the Mighty says, “By the All-Father’s beard feathers, I bind myself with a blood oath to aid the forest folk. They’ll have their lost treasure again, or may His celestial caw curse my bloodline for ten generations!”

Player 2: “To the tavern! Let us toast the empress—may the light of The Citadel preserve her—with a round of drinks on me!”

Again, here, some very simple roleplaying helps expand the campaign world, telling us in one instance that there is a bird-like overseer god in this world, that the concept of blood oaths carries weight, and that Mork (and perhaps his people) believe violating such an oath can give rise to a multi-generational curse. In the second instance, the inclusion of a blessing when the player roleplays the character mentioning the empress indicates the empress is deeply revered as a spiritual figure by some in this world, and that this particular form of spirituality includes the concept of celestial light as a source of blessing. The blessing emanates from something called The Citadel, which could be a divine plane of existence, a high temple in the material world, or any number of other concepts. Significantly, even if the player doesn't have a clear idea of what The Citadel might be, merely mentioning it encourages the other players or the GM to inquire about its meaning

Vocal Flourishes, Dialects, Accents, and Jargon

Significantly, none of the above examples rely on the use of distinctive voices or dialect. Indeed, some players or GMs may be less comfortable stretching their improv muscles by adding these elements. But those sorts of flourishes needn't be over-the-top or particularly complicated. Even a few subtle embellishments can make a world of difference. The GM might roleplay a shadowy figure delivering the warning, "It's already too late. You're all going to die." Those words in and of themselves, even if delivered in a bland conversational tone, already raise dramatic tension in the scene. But by simply lowering the voice to a whisper and perhaps adding a gravelly rasp, a GM can suggest all sorts of further implications. The players might wonder: Is the speaker a ghost or other apparition? Are we receiving a warning from a messenger of the gods or demons? Is this merely a mundane thug trying to frighten us by disguising his voice?

Likewise, the use of dialect doesn't mean a player has to be a master impressionist with a command of multiple regional accents. Often, less can be more. A player might want their character to say, "*I don't know how we're going to get out of this situation without dying.*" But, depending on their own concept of how their character speaks, the player might instead deliver the same bit of dialogue in any of the following different ways:

"Me think we dead now."

Here, the character might be unsophisticated or less educated, or might be from a campaign culture that values actions over words, letting their deeds speak louder than their utterances.

“With what cruel barbs do the brambles of fortune tug at my cloak! We are all of us dust, and to dust shall we return ere we escape this place where the seamsters of fate have ushered us.”

This might be a highly educated, sage-like character, or an overly dramatic one with bardic tendencies, or perhaps simply an insecure one who tries to overcompensate by using big words. Whatever the case may be, this line of dialogue also offers a tidbit about the world’s mythology, inasmuch as it references allegorical figures who spin or cut short mortal fates.

“Hssss. Thisss sscenario meanss our deathsss.”

Simply emphasizing the sibilances in this utterance suggests a character who might hail from a race of snake-people.

“Alas, I fear I’ve painted my last sunset.”

Peppering dialogue with references to a trade or craft is a very easy way to suggest a character’s background—in this case, that of an artist—through roleplaying.

Moreover, the very fact that different player characters might manifest different accents or regional or professional eccentricities in their speech patterns widens the campaign world, suggesting diverse cultures, nations, and backgrounds.

Collaborative Building Blocks

Perhaps most importantly, all this functions as something of a feedback loop. When the GM immerses players in a campaign chock full of evocative roleplaying, the players are likely to respond in kind, answering with their own distinctive embellishments that build on the GM’s foundation. Likewise, GMs who see their players enjoying themselves as they lean into roleplaying are more likely to pull additional improvisational moments out of their bag of roleplaying tricks.

Finally, it bears mentioning that when it comes to roleplaying as a form of worldbuilding, players and GMs should always remember it is a collective, collaborative endeavor. Roleplaying choices a player makes to augment a character or deepen the campaign setting should never make other players feel their own choices or opportunities for character development have been limited. It’s fine to reveal through roleplaying that your gnome character comes from an enclave of coastal gnomes whose hearts are ever drawn to the sea. But one should avoid suggesting that *all* gnomes share this yearning; one of your fellow players might have a very different concept for their gnome character and its place in the campaign world.

Likewise, don't step on the GM's toes. It's entirely fair to come up with a clever way to outsmart a trap or awkward social encounter set up by the GM, but players should also respect the world the GM is trying to portray and should, to the best of their abilities, find ways to be creative within the parameters of the chosen setting. For that reason, it is always a good idea for the GM to let the players know at the outset of a campaign if there are any aspects of the setting that should be considered sacrosanct and not subject to alteration. But with all that in mind, the most important thing to do when roleplaying is have fun; engage in as much or as little roleplaying as makes you comfortable so that the game never stops feeling like an opportunity for a group of friends to enjoy themselves.

TAKE YOUR CHARACTER ON A TRANSFORMATIVE JOURNEY:

How to Roleplay and Facilitate Character Arcs

Sage Stafford

Within the tabletop roleplaying game community, there are tons of blogs and articles centered around how to run a game session, how to compile notes, or how to use or create mechanics, but—rather surprisingly—not as much is written about what it is that brings us together in the first place: roleplaying. The ability to roleplay is often taken for granted, but it's worth examining how we can make the most out of the characters we embody and the stories we sculpt. Players vary drastically on how much initial investment they put into a character—some have a mere handful of words or phrases to guide their roleplay while others will have pages of fleshed out backstory, a Spotify playlist, and character art all before session zero. There's no right or wrong (or even better or worse) method for how much you should have initially prepared for your character; however much you've prepared, though, you should not expect the game master to build a story arc centered around your backstory and character for you.

All too often, players and GMs alike focus narrowly on the defining points of a character's backstory, rather than searching for the opportunity to discover new ones. When a character never grows beyond the events of their backstory, they are static, beholden to the immutable events of the past. A static character's story arc centers around resolving past conflicts,

which inherently limits the players' choice in how to interact with the conflict, the world, and each other. Dynamic characters, by contrast, are continually shaped by present events, and not every facet of their personality is informed by their past.

Let's look at some examples. Vengeance is a common motivation for adventuring: My (family, spouse, clan) were killed by (bandits, a dragon, devils), and I vow to make those responsible pay. There are exactly two ways that story resolves: You either exact revenge or you drop the pursuit of it. Vengeance or other motives centered on past events are not poor motivations for a character *per se*, but if the most pivotal events in your character's life have already transpired, it leaves both you and the GM little room to work with for developing that character's story further. This can easily lead to a static character if you're not careful. Such arcs can be salvaged, however, by the player coming up with a compelling answer to the question, "What now?" Much like Inigo Montoya pondering what he will do with the rest of his life at the end of *The Princess Bride*, it's up to the player to decide why their character is saying "yes" to the next story beat or quest. When players develop motivations for their characters to involve themselves in conflict, the story deepens and allows more opportunity for interesting dramatic tension and nuance.

When conflict arises, characters face the essential choice of leaning into their established beliefs and habits or choosing a different course of action. A character arc is the transformation or inner journey of a character as it relates to the events of the narrative and the consequences of their choices. Deciding how your character acts and internalizes the events of the campaign is the primary way to assert agency in a roleplaying game, even if the GM is not a collaborative storyteller by nature. As you are building a persona, leave room for questions that can only be answered through playing your character rather than by past actions.

The following are some of the questions I ask myself when building a character for a campaign or ask of my players when I'm the GM:

- What are the character's core principles? What magnitude of event would need to happen to cause them to waver in their beliefs?
- What emotional response does the character often lean on when they're in distress?
- What cause is most important to the character? What made them take up this cause? What would make them give it up?
- What are short- and long-term goals for the character?

Some questions should not have a clear answer at the outset of play—you should have a vague idea at best. As the campaign progresses, return to these questions periodically and contemplate if your answers have changed.

If your answers have changed, reflect on how and why—and what recent events have impacted their perspective, beliefs, and habits. Consider how the relationships your character has with the other PCs and NPCs have developed—which individuals have they become closer to or withdrawn from? How do these changes to their perspective, beliefs, habits, and relationships manifest? In essence, you establish a characteristic, belief, or goal, reflect if it has changed over time, and convey how your character embodies that change through roleplay. This process of “establish, reflect, and convey” promotes intentional development of a character arc, which naturally deepens the player’s investment in the campaign and imbues the player with greater agency. Much like watching a beloved friend, family member, or pet grow, develop, and change, characters may take on an immensely satisfying or surprising emotional journey of their own that players bring to fruition.

When the players and GM create space for the characters to make bold or unpredictable decisions, everyone at the table shares in intensely memorable moments that open new avenues for story or roleplay opportunities. Roleplaying game systems celebrate unpredictability through employing dice mechanics or other means to generate random chance, and playing a character who not only adapts to the events of the narrative, but is shaped by them, introduces healthy unpredictability through roleplay.

Much like life, campaigns become monotonous when everyone at the table continuously makes the same predictable choices. Whether it’s the GM constantly staging combat with a single foe in a 30-foot by 30-foot room or a player always throwing sand in a creature’s eyes, relying on the same tactics, aesthetics, or characteristics quickly becomes stale. Likewise, pervasive unpredictability from the players or GM is equally tiresome. Healthy unpredictability stems from successful or failed dice rolls and character and plot developments that are grounded in the logic of the narrative.

For example, in the *Venture Maidens* podcast’s Favor campaign, I play a seventeen-year-old satyr bard by the name of Aoife Flannery. Initially, Aoife aspired to be a world-famous fashion designer, and I established her as someone who loves to be swept up in new experiences and go wherever the wind carries her. After several sessions and experiences with the fey, I realized that my expectations for the kinds of stories we would be engaging in were not aligned with the GM’s, and that caused friction for how my

character and I were able to interact with the world and the plot. While I expected we would be engaged in the stories of the mortal realm being influenced by the fey, we were thrust headlong into fey territory.

However, once I understood what kind of stories the GM was striving for, I reflected on Aoife's recent experiences and allowed her to adapt. Since she was able to strike a favorable deal with a fey, she began to seek out new opportunities to become more entangled in fey courtly intrigue. Eventually she pledged herself as a vassal to a fey court. While her pledge was surprising and memorable to my fellow players and their characters, it wasn't unfounded, as I had conveyed that she was leaning into her newfound ambition over several sessions. Thus far, Aoife's character arc depicts her journey from flighty and day-dreaming teenager to ambitious diplomat, and her journey is intrinsically tied to the ability to make meaningful choices.

While players can develop satisfying character arcs without assistance from the GM, most campaigns are enriched when the players are empowered to make meaningful choices. In order for decision points to be truly meaningful, they must meet the following criteria:

- The players must have the information required to make an informed decision.
- The players must know they are making a decision.
- The story will change based on their decision.
- The decision is final.
- The characters experience the consequences of their choices.
- Whenever any of these criteria are not met, player agency is diminished.

As players should have intentionality when making decisions, GMs must have intentionality when *presenting* decisions. If a choice is presented that does not meet the criteria, the GM is responsible for coming up with a good reason as to *why*—since agency is intrinsically tied to how impactful a decision is to the players. The more agency players have in a story, the more invested they need to be in the decision-making process, which in turn requires them to have a greater understanding of their character, the conflict, and the world.

While the majority of tabletop roleplaying games rely on the fundamental push-and-pull structure of “GM presents a situation / players react to the situation,” that doesn't mean the players and GM are in direct opposition. Rather, the players and the GM form a partnership, and both halves of the partnership must uphold their end of the bargain and be open to renegotiating when the partnership is suffering.

Everyone requires different levels of preparation to play a character or run a session, but it is essential to allow space for developing your character or story. When your character has a string of bad rolls, makes mistakes, falls unconscious, or even dies, don't force them to remain unflappable in the face of adversity; when you allow your character to admit their missteps and misfortune and be shaped by it, they become more believable and easier to roleplay. As in life, we learn so much more from our mistakes than our successes. Character arcs don't need to encompass huge personality shifts—like Walter White's shift from mild-mannered high school chemistry teacher to drug kingpin in *Breaking Bad*—instead, consider Foggy Nelson from *Daredevil*. Foggy begins the series in Matt Murdock's shadow as a loveable every-man. However, when he is confronted with Matt's double-life as Daredevil, Foggy stands up to Matt and describes how Matt's vigilantism flies straight in the face of all they're trying to accomplish with their law firm. Over the course of the series, we watch Foggy grow more confident and willing to fight for his principles.

When considering character development in your campaign, either as a player or the GM, don't be afraid to request scenes and talk through ideas for where the story is going. Collaborating on your collective stories can only heighten the creative potential of your game and reward you with memorable and surprising moments for years to come.

GENIUS, NOT OMNISCIENCE:

A Player's Guide to Roleplaying Intelligence & Wisdom

Basheer Ghouse

You are playing Azagh the Pluripotent, a venerable wizard with decades of experience in tactics, a comprehensive education in magical theory, and a library of classical literature from across the known realms. Azagh's mind is a peerless thing, matched against dragons, gods, and timeless abominations. A final battle is nigh, and your allies look to you for guidance in forming your battle plan.

Unfortunately, *you* are a pretty normal person. Maybe you were good in school. Maybe you're well-read. Maybe you're even pretty smart. But, statistically, you're probably not one of the smartest people to ever exist, so you've got some barriers in the way of playing a super-genius.

Worse, you don't even get to cheat and just make them omniscient like a fiction writer might. Because, unlike a writer, you have to portray that intelligence live. So your goal isn't merely to make a smart character, but to *convince your fellow players that this is a smart character*.

Defining Genius

The first step to playing a world-shaking mind (whether you're talking about high intelligence or wisdom) is defining your goal. It's easy to look at these stats as kind of a magic power: If they're high enough, you should be making Correct Choices, and if you aren't, then you're not playing the character right—but this isn't helpful or accurate.

There are many ways to define intelligence and wisdom. For our purposes, let's assume the following:

- Intelligence covers information processing, rote memorization, long-term planning, puzzle solving, and investigative skill. As such, a high-intelligence character should *know many facts* and *be able to synthesize information* while a low intelligence character shouldn't.
- Wisdom covers common sense, spirituality, empathy, willpower, and perception. As such, a high wisdom character should *be aware of others and the world around them* and *difficult to dupe or suborn*, while a low wisdom character shouldn't.

This can all be pretty daunting, so you can make it easier by having your character be a specialist. Plenty of smart people are mostly smart within their area of expertise and are capable of shocking incompetence outside of it. Sherlock Holmes is a peerless detective who doesn't know that the earth revolves around the sun, while *Disco Elysium's* Harrier DuBois is a peerless detective best described as a living garbage fire. Picking a specialty makes it much easier to convincingly portray a high stat.

Is your high-intelligence character a specialist in languages and etymology? Arcane theories around necromancy? Forbidden knowledge of the far realms? Forensics? What do they consider unimportant and, therefore, what do they not care to apply their intelligence to?

Is your high wisdom character a spiritualist interpreting the will of gods? An explorer in tune with the wilds? Do they just kind of *get* what makes people tick? Are they extraordinarily composed in the face of adversity? Are they willing to admit when they're out of their depth?

Pick skills that support this concept, narrow your conception of intelligence to the specialty, and you're already well on your way to portraying a believable, exceptional intelligence. After all, you've narrowed your scope from excelling at Everything All the Time to excelling at One Thing Most of the Time.

Most importantly, it lets you roll with failures by portraying them as something outside of your character's own interpretation of that high ability score.

Leveraging Your Advantages

While you don't have the superhuman mental acuity of your character, you do have some pretty significant advantages:

1. You get to take time to make decisions that your character doesn't have.
2. Your adventures take place in a fictional world with genre conventions.
3. You have the Internet (and other research tools) at your disposal.
4. You are playing a game without the risk of actual life or death.
5. You're playing the game collaboratively with other people.

Time Is on Your Side

While your character is cold-reading characters in seconds, analyzing battlefields in the middle of combat, or deciphering murderous puzzles in a manner of minutes, *you* aren't. You are sitting at a table playing a game.

Because of that, what takes your character *seconds* could take you *minutes*—or more. If a session ends mid-fight or on a dramatic cliffhanger, you could take hours or days to do research, put together your character's next few flashes of brilliance, or dissect what you know about an NPC. Back in the game, you can bring up these new historical tidbits or neat factoids, sprinkle redressed quotes from ancient philosophers into conversations, and know a suspicious amount about Roman concrete or whatever else seems relevant. Being unconscious during combat is a *particularly* good time to dissect a puzzle or put together the pieces of a plan.

For a low-stat character, you can be conscientious about sometimes doing things incorrectly. Take what you know about a situation, decide on what your character has overlooked or failed to figure out, and go from there. Remember that low intelligence and/or wisdom doesn't mean doing the wrong thing all the time, it often just means acting on incorrect information or without care.

Genre Savvy

When you're playing with a long-term group, or your group is using a lot of pre-written content, a good way to play smarter than you are is to be aware of the genre of the story. If you're used to how your GM runs stories (or, as a GM, you're used to how your players react to situations), pre-empting that *to a degree* can be an effective way to portray a high-intelligence/wisdom character.

This is important to do in moderation and is probably worth discussing with your group beforehand. There's a thin line between using genre conventions to play someone more competent than you are and being a

prick who's ruining the fun. You should aim to have good hunches and quick deductions, not short-circuit huge segments of the plot or ruin dramatic twists.

It can help to play into a character's flaws. Someone who doesn't act on or communicate these deductions until it's almost too late can make these sort of pre-empts more bearable for everyone else. Once you've got the hang of it, playing Sherlock Holmes to everyone else's collective Watson can be entertaining, effective, and maybe get you the good will to massively derail a plot without everyone getting annoyed by it.

Similarly, if you're playing a character with *low* mental ability scores, you can do the opposite. Play the Watson to everyone else's Holmes, or make mistakes that fit the genre to sell the stat. Be the guy other people explain things to, so their characters feel smarter.

The Power of Friendship

Alone, you may not have the brains to be Azagh the Pluripotent. But with the help of your fellow players, you can combine your minds into an intelligence unlike anything else in the setting.

Or, at least, be wrong significantly faster.

The key to this is the separation between your character and you. You're not trying to fool your friends into thinking that you're a genius, or infinitely wise, you just want to play a game where your character is.

If your group is on board with it, you can simply have a character take credit for ideas or solutions you all came up with out of character. This works especially well if other characters have low mental stats but are smart players. This should be collaborative; you don't want to steal credit, but further the fiction in a convenient manner.

Similarly, you can use your group as a resource between sessions. Ask them for relevant quotes or about subjects they're passionate about, and try to work those into your next session.

For a high-intelligence character, if you want to *really* sell them as a loremaster who has delved into the hidden mysteries of the world, then your first step, before anything else I've noted in this essay, is really simple. You go to your GM and you say the following magic words: "I want to play a character really invested in the setting's history. Could you tell me about any important stuff my character would have researched or otherwise know about?" Most of the time, unless your GM is *really* into collaborative worldbuilding (and maybe even if they are), there's plenty of material they'll be happy to share—thus making you (and your character) better informed and prepared.

For a low-stat character, you're working in reverse. If one of your fellow players misunderstands something or has a spectacularly bad idea out-of-character, have your character go with that in-character. On the flip side, if you have a good idea, let another player's character suggest it in-character. (It can also help to assuage your own ego to occasionally declare that you know what the correct thing to do is in this situation, but your character doesn't.)

Tying It Together

This article is a toolkit. Everything in it can be used on its own but works best when tied together into a cohesive whole. Don't obsess over making sure you pull off a technique correctly: If something stalls, drop it and swap to another technique. The surest route to failure is getting tied up in the idea of portraying *yourself* as a genius instead of your *character*.

Figure out your actual objectives, collaborate with your fellow players, roll with failures, and things may not end up genius—but will work out all right.

SPEAK FRIEND AND ENTER:

Using Character Connections to Deepen Roleplay

Shanna Germain

Being a great roleplayer can sometimes feel like a solitary experience. There's a lot of focus on how you are playing your character—your voice, your mannerisms, your descriptions, and so on. If you're a shy, quiet, or inexperienced player, that can feel like a lot of pressure. On the other hand, if you're an extrovert or someone who's really comfortable roleplaying, you can run the risk of overshadowing the other players or accidentally appearing a little self-focused.

Thankfully, you're not (usually) alone at the table. You're surrounded by other players who also want to roleplay, and one of the best ways to facilitate that is by leaning into the relationships between not just the players, but also the player *characters*.

While many games have built-in mechanics to get this started—you grew up in the same town; you're siblings, lovers, rivals, or best friends; or you shared in wonderful or traumatic previous experiences—deep, ongoing roleplay between characters is something that happens best at the table. It's in the small but important moments where your character invites another PC to shine, or where you help each through a bit of trouble, or where another character gives yours a gift that's imbued with meaning.

Of course, this kind of roleplay doesn't typically just *happen*. It takes work and focus on everyone's part. A great starting point is to think about what you want in real-world friendships and relationships and bringing those

ideas to the table. There's tons of research out there on what makes people feel seen, loved, and appreciated in relationships of all kinds, and it's not always what we think.

So let's steal some of those concepts for our characters and put them to use.

Hey, Wanna Help?

One of the easiest and most common ways to use character connections to generate roleplay is by actively having your character invite other characters into your moments, both big and small. This is especially useful if you're a confident or experienced player, and you're looking to make space for quieter or newer players. Whenever you can, go out of your way to make "me" moments into "we" moments by giving other characters a clear opening and making it easy for them to join you.

Perhaps the simplest way to do this is to ask a question in-voice, ideally one that gives the opportunity for more than a yes or no answer. These can be direct and action-oriented—"Hey, friend, do you think your owl could fly over the area and see if there are any gardens nearby? I was thinking about trying to steal us some potatoes for dinner."

Or they can be more thoughtful, such as, "What do you think about this plan to steal the crown from the museum? Is that something we really should be doing?"

Asking for help, insight, thoughts, or even reactions to things that are going on around you make it easy to learn more about both the situation and the other characters while creating conversations or experiences that are directly related to what's going on (or what will be going on) at the table.

It's also a great way for players to start trying on their characters' voices and reactions. Sometimes coming up with how a character sounds—or how they experience the world or other players—is hard to do in a vacuum. Having something to react to, via something like a request for help or information, can really get that the ball rolling.

I Remembered Your Birthday!

How wonderful is it when someone remembers your birthday, your favorite author, or your dream of playing the cello? When they ask how your beloved pet's doing or if your twisted ankle's feeling better? These are not hugely important things, but they tend to mean a lot to people.

Same for player characters. Remembering and acting on these kinds of details, especially when they're not plot-related, can go really far in creating roleplaying opportunities.

However, doing so requires three things: You have to pay attention to what matters to the other characters, you have to remember it, and then you have to find ways to use it.

- **Pay Attention.** Let's say you're moving through a swamp when another character mentions in passing that they've always wanted a frog companion but sadly they're allergic. A tiny detail, an off-hand remark, but if you're listening, you now have a lovely little fact about them. A wish and a problem that you can help fulfill and solve. (Or, if you don't have that kind of relationship—something you can thwart or throw in their face.)
- **Remember It.** If your memory's shoddy (or if you're in a long campaign or there are more than a few other PCs), the solution is simple: write it down. You could give each PC their own page or their own header in your notebook—or their own tab or column on a spreadsheet. Anything should work, so long as you can easily look up these little details mid-game. Drawing can help too. It's hard to forget if every time you look at the page, a friendly little frog is staring back at you.
- **Use It.** Next time you're hurt and someone is healing you, you might ask them if, by-and-by, they know of a way to deal with frog allergies, which you can then share with your friend. Or you might point out the allergy clinic you find in town. Or maybe the frog comes first—maybe you see an adorable rock that looks like a frog, and you stick it in your pocket to give them next time they're feeling down (or up). Perhaps you find a breeder who raises hypoallergenic frogs and your whole group goes on an adventure to visit them. Or maybe you just get the entire group excited about catching the perfect companion and you all go off to the swamp with your nets and your high hopes.

Details like this don't always have to be used to bolster a friendly relationship. If you have a rivalry with the other character, maybe you get your own frog companion first, just to make them jealous. Or you stick a frog under their pillow just to see what being allergic to frogs really entails.

As long as there's an opportunity to use the other characters' wants, needs, or experiences to create interesting interactions and moments, you're doing it right. (With the usual caveat: If your character's going to be a jerk to another character, make sure the player is okay with it.)

I Made This for You: Gifts and Goodies

Tied closely to remembering details is the giving of gifts. This might be buying someone their favorite food at the market, getting a local smith to make a piece of armor that suits them perfectly, or offering them something of your own that they can make better use of. It might be for a special event like a birthday, to celebrate an important moment between the two of you, to try and apologize for a wrongdoing, or just because you feel like it.

Gifts, particularly tactile objects, are full of opportunities for roleplay moments, because they can be used as tactile and concrete stand-ins for our characters' emotions and connections, and they can exist for a long time. A rope can be used over and over again—and will remind the characters of their relationship every time. Maybe the rope got a name the first time you all used it to escape a particularly difficult fight, and it has now become like a member of the party. You tell stories about it. You despair when it gets frayed or cut in half or stolen. If the relationship between the characters goes badly, one character might give it back or destroy it or throw it away, all of which can echo and deepen the roleplaying experience.

Maybe someday the rope gets made into something new—four necklaces that hold special charms with your group's secret symbol on it. Or it gets woven into a basket and given to another character to house their new frog companion.

A gift doesn't need to be perfect. In both real life and at the table, a gift sometimes says a lot more about you than it does the person you're giving it to. A warrior giving his new bard friend a heavy hand-crafted sword shows us what the warrior loves, and that's great roleplaying too. The bard friend, who may not even be able to heft their new weapon, now has to decide how to respond. Do they say "Thanks, but it's not really for me?" Do they start taking sword lessons? Or do they hang it in a place of honor on their wall, where everyone can see it as soon as they walk in the door?

And then there are "gifts"—those things you give another character that might intentionally or accidentally hurt them in some way. (Again, it's a good idea to talk to the player ahead of time if you're going to do this.) Not something that's going to kill them, of course, like poisoned soup, but something that has more of an emotional impact. A letter from their estranged mother that you didn't give them years ago. A ring you picked up at a pawn shop, not knowing it was the same ring that they once gave a loved one. A pet frog, when you didn't know they were allergic to frogs.

F Is for Failure (and Friendship)

While it's easy to be there for each other during the good times—it's almost a built-in trope that you go to the pub to celebrate after a rousing success—it's a little harder to know how to reach across the table when things go poorly, especially outside of a combat situation.

We know that people appreciate and trust others who are willing to talk about their failures and show their weaknesses, and we can use that with our characters too. Showing weakness might seem counterintuitive in a game where the goal is often to become strong and fight monsters, but it has a power all its own. Any time a character fails at something that's important to them, whether that's through bad dice rolls or a narrative decision, it creates a great opportunity to get closer to other characters.

If your character's the one who failed, you could seek another character's opinion on why it went so poorly—or ask them to coach you on that skill so you might succeed at it next time. If someone you know has failed, offer to cook them a meal, take them to their favorite hunting spot, or just sit with them while they cry.

How characters respond during difficult times creates a plethora of opportunities for roleplay and relationships. If your character attempted to summon a demon and failed, they may ask the other characters for help in trying again. One character might happily show up, having readied their most powerful spells. Another might help, but only reluctantly, because they're afraid of demons, they don't believe that it's right to summon other creatures, or maybe just that it's a terrible idea. And maybe one character won't help at all, because they just can't watch you go through that experience one more time, but they promise to be there for you when you're done, whether you succeed or fail.

Get Engaged

In the end, all these tips really come down to one thing: get engaged. Not necessarily in the wedding sense (although that also makes great roleplay) but in the being present sense.

Make it part of your gaming goal to pay attention and care about the things that matter to the other players and their characters, just as you would your friends and family. Then have your character use that knowledge in whatever way feels right to them, whether it be to magically remove their allergies, cook them their favorite meal after a defeat, or just sit next to them by the fire while they tell you the stories of their dreams.

EMBRACE THE EMBARRASSMENT:

Or, How I Learned to Stop Worrying
and Love It When I Bomb

Shareef Jackson

Being a player for the actual play show *Rivals of Waterdeep* was a life-changing experience. It was my first time in a long-term campaign, and the show helped ensure my love for tabletop gaming would be life-long. After that great experience playing, I was fascinated to try GMing but was also a bit intimidated. I thought I needed a mastery of every single rule of the game before I could GM and wasn't sure how I'd manage all of the improv necessary to create a fun experience. Here are some of the tricks I used that helped me finally learn to embrace the embarrassment (and GMing).

Failure Is Always an Option . . . But Not Always a Bad Thing

One of the things that scares people most about GMing is the (likely) possibility that you'll embarrass yourself in front of your players. But, as a GM, trying to avoid embarrassment is a futile exercise. If you must look up a rule, forget a player in the combat initiative order, or you forget how a certain spell works, it's natural to feel embarrassed and maybe feel like you're failing at GMing. But remember: This happens to everyone!

The easiest thing to do if you're feeling self-conscious about something that happens in-game is to just try to laugh it off—your players will be laughing with you, not at you. Everyone mispronounces words sometimes

(whether real-world words or fantasy-world words) or forgets a character's name or accidentally shows their players part of the map they weren't supposed to see until later. No one's ever run a perfect session, so don't expect yourself to.

When you make an error or forget a rule as GM, one of the easiest ways to mitigate it is to just make a quick decision and continue the game; you can look it up after the session and make a note so that you can get it right next time. The players will likely be relieved that you made an executive decision, and they can just focus on playing the game (and not spending valuable game-time searching for a rule). If you are in a game that has an audience, there will definitely be a few viewers that will love to correct you, but you can't let those viewers direct how you run the game.

Doing a Voice for the Voiceless

When leading a group of adventurers in a roleplaying game, one way to provide an immersive experience is to give voices to your characters. Luckily, you do not need to be a trained voice actor to accomplish this. By focusing on the purpose each character serves in your story, you can make slight alterations to your natural voice that will serve the story well.

One easy way to do this is to have a list of traits that can be represented by slight changes to your normal voice. Three examples are nervousness, paranoia, and confidence. A nervous character can speak hesitantly, increasing in rapidity before revealing important information. On the other hand, a paranoid character can speak in a hushed tone, constantly looking around to observe their surroundings. Finally, a confident character can speak in a voice that starts low and rises near the end of the sentence. These small changes mean that as a GM, you don't have to come up with an entirely new voice for every character that you plan to use.

The traits and voice alterations mentioned above have an obvious use for characters that the players are likely to interact with, but they can also be lifesavers when players suggest speaking to a random character that you have not prepared for. Instead of trying to think of an entire character profile on the fly, choosing a trait and letting that drive the changes to your voice can be just as effective. Try keeping a list of traits and names at the ready. You can either assign each name to a trait beforehand or randomly select one in the moment. Either way, it makes impromptu character creation a bit easier.

If you decide that slight voice alterations are not enough, you can also try to perform an entirely new voice. A good strategy is to give an impression of a voice that you've enjoyed in film or television. Don't worry about sounding overly exaggerated. That only adds to the fun and humor of the

campaign! Making your players laugh is always a win, even in a campaign with a serious tone. Unless you have an uncanny knack for voices (and/or are a voice actor), it is probably wise to only do this for important characters that will be part of the campaign long-term and not for NPCs the PCs will probably never see again. Be sure to write down some notes that will help you remember how you did the character's voice in case it's a long time before the PCs see them again.

One thing to be careful about when experimenting with new voices and traits is avoid being (accidentally) gender essentialist. While any character can exhibit any trait, pay attention to how these voices and traits are distributed amongst your NPCs. For instance, if most of your female-presenting characters have stereotypically feminine characteristics that make them appear physically weak or overly emotional, then you are recreating some of the same gender stereotypes that we see in the real world. By reinforcing these biases in your game, it can be hurtful to your players; whereas avoiding these kinds of stereotypes can help your players immerse themselves into (and be more comfortable playing in) your game world.

Race is another thing to consider when developing voices and traits. Beware of giving all characters of a certain race the same traits and voices. Doing this can lead to replicating real world racial stereotypes, which can have a negative effect on your players. You are, of course, free to play in a game world that has discrimination in it, but the characters who are being discriminated against should be represented by a diverse set of traits and voices.

Elementary, My Dear Game Master

Playing highly educated and/or genius characters can also prove to be a challenge. Advanced knowledge of the topics your NPCs are experts in is not needed to portray them as hyperintelligent in the game. A few details here and there can be enough to sell the character's intellect to your players, and the rest can be handwaved or handled by out-of-character explanation.

For example, if you wish to show a character who possesses a strong scientific curiosity, you can show them using the scientific method—coming up with a hypothesis and then testing to see if the question is true or not. But as long as your NPC has a consistent focus on being inquisitive, the players will get the message. This method can also be used for characters with a high aptitude for magic and/or arcana. It is not necessary to memorize a litany of magical terms or to describe the character as a typical gray-haired, elder wizard. You define what makes a great magician, and that can vary by character. For example, a character that uses simple magical

spells to make common tasks easier fits the bill. Imagine someone who has silverware levitating and feeding a wizard meal from a self-cooking oven. Even better, imagine a character who resurrects characters from the dead, or even fly! You achieve these by rolling dice (and hiding the results from your players) or simply by saying that the actions always happen. Either way, the players will be left with the feeling that the character has a high magical aptitude.

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You might feel embarrassed creating characters with different education, race, or gender backgrounds from yourself, but including characters of different races, genders, and voices will help your world feel more vibrant and alive. And remember: Embracing the embarrassment is part of the fun. Instead of wasting energy trying to avoid embarrassment at every step, accept that it will exist and use these strategies to help your games run more smoothly.

EMBODYING THE DARK SIDE:

How to Effectively Roleplay Villains

Michael E. Shea

Many GMs treat monsters as nothing but statistics. They move. They attack. They die. Villains often act the same—moving, attacking, and dying—with the added step of a twirl of the mustache and a witty intro line (“I’ll get you, my pretty!”). That’s about it.

But villains and monsters are likely the most important NPCs our heroes interact with. Sure, our heroes might have an interesting conversation with Grettel the local meat pie baker. But monsters? They’re facing monsters all the time. And villains are running the show. Villains are often the reason the PCs are doing anything at all.

It’s worth the time and energy to roleplay villains, and thus it’s worth our time to know *how* to roleplay villains.

Step into the Shoes of Your Villains

Who are they? What do they want? What steps are they taking to get there? These three questions help you get into the mind of the villain. It helps you understand their motivations, their background, their goals, and the steps they take to accomplish them. It gives you practical outcomes you can use at both macro and micro levels in your game. It guides the dialog when the villain talks to the characters. It guides the major beats of the campaign—each built from one of the villain’s main goals.

Putting yourself into your villain's shoes gives you something to consider every session you prepare. What is your villain doing right now? How are they moving their quests forward? Who's helping them? What reactions are they taking based on the actions of the PCs? Our villains aren't sitting in a throne waiting to be killed. They're just as active as the PCs are in pursuing their goals.

This is true roleplaying. We're *becoming* those villains for a short while. We're not coming up with mechanics or subsystems. We're *going there*. The more we roleplay our villain, even when off-screen, the better that villain feels in the games we run—even if they're not there themselves.

What Does Your Villain's Day Look Like?

One way to get yourself into the head of your villain is to ask what a day in their lives looks like. If you were a planar-traveling arch-lich, how would you spend your day? What spells would you prepare? Which spheres of the multiverse would you visit? What big thousand-year projects are you working on? What does your daily to-do list look like? This style of thought gets us a level deeper into the lives of our villains—again, true roleplaying—and lets us know where this villain comes from when it's time for the characters to get involved.

Build Resilient Villainous Quests

When pondering your villain's plans and quests, ensure no one step in these chains of quests is *required* to accomplish the villain's overall goal. If villainous quests and steps are too brittle, the characters can thwart the entire plan by just breaking one link in the chain. What if Frodo went off by himself, threw the ring off the Brandywine ferry into the river, walked a couple of hundred miles away from it, and then disappeared? The ring might go missing for another thousand years before some fisherfolk accidentally finds it. You don't want your villain's whole plan to rely on just one quest. The villain's plans should go *wide*—with multiple potential successful paths the characters must cut off, one by one, before truly thwarting (and hopefully facing) the villain.

I like to refer to this as the “three of five keys” quest model. Imagine a villain wants to open a door to the Other Side with five locks. The villain must find each of the five keys to open the door. But the characters find out about this plan and the keys, so they too go hunting for the keys. All they need is one key. Melt it down, and the villain's quest is thwarted. But what if, instead, the door only needed *three* keys and five such keys existed out there in the world? Now the PCs must find and destroy three keys to stop the door from being unlocked. Even if two keys are

destroyed, three keys still remain that can open the door. Maybe that final struggle for the final key happens at the very door itself—a great place for a villainous showdown.

In the “three of five keys” quest model, a villainous quest continues even if the PCs start to thwart one branch or another. This is a resilient quest chain since breaking one link in the chain doesn’t break the whole villainous quest.

Where to Get Ideas for Villainous NPCs

But how do we come up with villains in the first place? The answer is the same as any other idea you have for your games: anywhere and everywhere. That’s not exactly useful or practical advice, so let me give you some other ideas. Borrow villains from popular fiction. Books, movies, TV shows, video games, comics—all these sources often include wonderful villains we can pilfer for our games. The creators of these villains spent a lot of time considering how they act, what they want, etc. That’s all material we can pilfer and drop right into our games. It gives us built-in hooks, backgrounds, mannerisms, appearances—everything we need to make such a villain come to life in our world.

Of course, we can change the villain to make it unique for our game. Switch genders, backgrounds, species, or appearances—or all the above—to make your villain unique and prevent your players from figuring out your inspirations. You also don’t need to use only villains from popular fiction. Maybe your evil wizard looks and sounds a lot like Doc Brown from *Back to the Future* but with a dark and sinister edge. Maybe your villain is Gandalf if he *had* taken the One Ring.

Stealing villains from popular fiction saves you a *lot* of trouble hand-selecting your goals, backgrounds, motivations, mannerisms, accents, approaches, and all the rest. It all comes baked in.

Villainous Roleplaying as Prep

Getting into the heads of our villains helps us prepare our games. Knowing what our villains are doing, who they’re sending out to accomplish their goals, and how their plans progress tells us what’s going on and how the characters might get involved. Villain-focused prep builds out the world as a living place with moving parts. The PCs (and their players!) feel the urgency of the situation when they know their villain is digging into ancient temples looking for items of unimaginable power to fuel their diabolic plans.

We can expose these plans to the characters through written letters we write during our prep. Not all roleplaying has to occur at the table. Sometimes a note found on a dead body containing the admonishments of a villain for their underling's failure shows the PCs a piece of the villain's plan.

We might even break the fourth wall and email flash fiction to our players showing scenes the PCs don't witness. This can shake players up a little bit if they're too wired around their PC as their only view of the world, but it brings up interesting questions about what you know but your *character* doesn't when done right. Flash fiction between villains and their elite henchmen is a great way to spotlight those henchmen before they show up in front of the characters and likely get killed.

These sorts of villainous handouts and flash fiction are great ways to roleplay without being put on the spot. You can write such things, edit them, ensure they're focused on the right stuff, and ensure they reveal exactly what you want to reveal and nothing else in a way that roleplaying at the table simply can't do.

Writing villainous handouts is its own style of game prep and a fantastic tool for our own villainous arsenal.

Henchmen, Sidekicks, and Criers

Good villains have good henchmen, sidekicks, and criers. Nearly every James Bond movie has a side-villain—sometimes one that's more interesting than the villain himself. This henchman shows up often, getting right into the PC's world and view. While the villain may not show up until the end of a campaign, sidekicks show up early and often. And if they die off in a battle? There's always another henchman. You might even introduce a handful of notable henchmen through rumors, flash fiction, or those recovered letters described earlier. Like villains, the PCs should learn about henchmen before they face them in battle.

Henchmen can take on various forms. They might be big brutes like ogres or giants. They might be deadly assassins or hired mages. They're often more physical than psychological. Villains themselves often take up the role as the mastermind. Henchmen have something *unique* though. It might be a particular weapon they carry or a history. They might have a relationship (likely a bad one) with one of the characters. They might be a particularly strange type of monster like an oni, golem, rakshasa, or marilith.

Criers are a different type of NPC. Criers come right out of pro wrestling—announcing villains far and wide. They describe the villain's track record. They build the villain up in the minds of anyone who listens—including the PCs. Criers are often physically weak themselves—

no direct threat to the PCs—but annoying as all get-out. They serve two purposes: to teach the players about the villains—building up the villain in the PCs’ minds—and to make the PCs and players *really hate* the villain *and* their stupid crier.

Criers can be just about any type of humanoid but might also serve as a familiar like an imp, pseudodragon, or summoned sentient animal of some sort. Criers aren’t strong and are likely unable to defend themselves. Killing them may be one of life’s great true joys but there’s always another crier waiting in the wings.

Get into the Mind of Your Villain

One doesn’t need fancy generators or new mechanical systems to build great villains in one’s RPG. The more we think about our villains in the game’s world itself—their motivation, their goal, and the steps they take to accomplish it—the easier it becomes to roleplay that villain on or off screen. And we can focus on one question as we think about our villains:

What’s our villain doing right now?

POWER AND STYLE:

Roleplaying in Combat, Roleplaying Through Combat

Keith Ammann

In recent years, I've seen a theme pop up repeatedly in discussion of tabletop roleplaying games: that some games focus on roleplaying, while others focus on combat. The implication is that combat and roleplaying are mutually exclusive. To this way of thinking, the “three pillars of play” in *Dungeons & Dragons*, for instance, consist of two pillars (social interaction and exploration) that are about roleplaying and one (combat) that isn't. More roleplaying means less combat; more combat means less roleplaying.

I don't know why so many players have come to think of combat and roleplaying as opposite ends of a spectrum. To me, they're two different variables. Sure, you can get deeply into character while acting out a whispered conversation full of double meanings on a ballroom floor or interrogating sea creatures about the locations of hazardous rocks, but it's also easy to conduct social interaction and exploration without any roleplaying at all, by reducing them to the bare mechanics of ability checks. Similarly, while it's possible to treat combat as nothing more than a series of tactical calculations and die rolls, that's a self-imposed limitation. Combat encounters offer an abundance of opportunities for creative expression.

I'm the Best There Is at What I Do

If you spend eight years in college studying medicine, plus another several years beyond that as a resident, you're not *incidentally* a doctor. That experience, and that expertise, are going to be central to who you are as a person. Similarly, even the lowest-level player character adventurers possess training, blessings, and powers significantly above and beyond those of ordinary folk, and these endowments shape them.

So does the fact that, as adventurers, they live dangerous lives, ones in which mistakes can spell not merely failure but death. Successful adventurers become the subjects of heroic tales. Unsuccessful adventurers, if they're remembered at all, become the subjects of *cautionary* tales. You may not spend all your downtime thinking about how to make the highest and best use of your PC's unique abilities, but they do. They're obsessed with it; they need to be.

After a day of adventuring, before going to sleep, the fighter replays battles in his head, re-creates the movements, reflects on how an opponent's blow slipped past his defenses and how he should parry a similar blow in a fight yet to come. The wizard jots down reflections on the relative merits of *fireball* vs. *scorching ray*, while the bard devises clever put-downs and records them in a notebook for future use. The monk practices forms; the rogue fiddles with pilfered padlocks. The praying cleric opens his mind and heart to whatever guiding wisdom his deity sends him in return. You can use campfire scenes to roleplay your PC practicing their various abilities—helpfully reminding yourself, in the process, that those abilities exist.

This fixation on performance, essential to PCs' survival, pays off in combat. Knowing how your PC's class features, maneuvers, and spells can be used most effectively enables you to *roleplay their competence*. The fighter aims a Trip Attack on her foe intending to gain advantage on her follow-up—or chooses a Distracting Strike in order to set up the rogue instead, or forgoes her own attack altogether for a Commander's Strike because she knows the ranger is a crack marksman who can deal more damage with a well-placed shot. The druid casts *fog cloud* over losing battles to cover his allies' withdrawal, because creatures can't make opportunity attacks against foes they can't see. The Trickery cleric, casting *minor illusion*, always creates auditory rather than visual illusions because she knows that something you hear but don't see is more reliably convincing than something you see but don't hear. The PCs' preferences for certain ways of solving problems, their informed decisions made repeatedly across different situations, cohere over time into a style.

A character's combat role may dictate choice of weapon or a certain positioning on the battlefield, but there's more than one way to perform a combat role. The glaive-wielding Battle Master strides forward a few steps and plants herself, silently daring her foes to enter her long weapon's reach. The paladin calls purifying flame from his sword and authoritatively orders the enemy to withdraw or face the consequences. The Berserker barbarian rushes her adversaries, screaming. They all fulfill the same combat role—front-line warrior, positioned to soak up damage as well as deal it—but their combat *personalities* differ dramatically.

In D&D, players are encouraged to choose personality traits, ideals, bonds, and flaws for their PCs. All of these can be put to use in combat. The warlock who values her life and autonomy above all else hangs back when a fight breaks out, unwilling to follow others into peril. The ranger who kills monsters to purge his own guilt continues fighting even when seriously wounded. The cleric intolerant of other faiths gets an itchy hammer hand in the presence of cultists.

Some game masters like to treat players to “cutsscenes” in which they roleplay moments of transformative personal growth when PCs level up, especially at levels where they gain new subclass features. I enjoy doing this myself, but an excellent alternative is to shift the roleplaying moment to the first use of the new feature in combat. Draw out the moment and describe it in detail: Is your PC confident that their new ability will work as intended, or are they attempting something they've never done before out of desperation? Is it even something they're doing deliberately, or is it an unsought boon from a deity or patron or an eruption of previously untapped sorcerous power? What does it look, sound, and feel like in action? How does the PC react to the success of what they've just done—or to its failure? How do their allies react to the sight of it?

And remember: No matter what else you're doing with your turn, talking is always free, so make the most of it. Call out tactical orders to other PCs, compliment their successful strikes, and pep-talk them after their misses—or trash-talk them, if that's more your character's style. Play out friendly rivalries, like Gimli and Legolas at Helm's Deep. Lecture foes on the error of their ways and the comeuppance they're about to receive. Direct bystanders to safety. Sing or shout inspiring verses. Whatever your PC would be most focused on, aside from the fight itself, put it into words.

¹Wizards of the Coast designer Justice Arman once speculated hilariously on reskinned barbarians who harnessed emotions other than rage for their power. “These tears aren't for me,” the Sorrow barbarian warned.

Nonverbal Communication

Nonplayer characters are essential participants in social interaction scenes. In combat encounters, though, they can be functionally indistinguishable from a monster—and monsters are often nonverbal, either because they don't speak, because they don't speak the PCs' language, or because they don't have anything to say. In no way, however, does this mean that they don't express themselves—it just means they express themselves through action. And combat, at its heart, is action.

Using monsters' traits and attack actions to express their essential nature is a form of roleplaying for the GM. A monster that charges into melee, snarling and drooling, sends one kind of message about what that monster is like. A monster that hides in the shadows and snipes, skitters across the ceiling and drops on its prey, or disorients its opponents with psychic power or incomprehensible noises sends another. Play up the sensory aspects of these traits and attacks, the details that paint a monster as brutal, shifty, whimsical, fearsome, zealous, indifferent, or disturbing.

Don't stop there, though. There are other ways to express a monster's nature beyond what you find in its stat block. Describe its posture: Does it loom imperiously over its foes or circle them cautiously in a defensive crouch? Does it seem unwilling to venture far from a certain spot? Does it lunge straight for the nearest opponent or anticipate threats and preemptively neutralize them? Does it act with obvious and deliberate malice, zeroing in on the weakest-looking target present? Are there indications it would prefer to avoid a fight, if possible? Is it slow or quick to flee when badly wounded?

Playing a very intelligent creature or character—one significantly smarter than oneself—poses a particular challenge. I find it useful to keep in mind an aspect of intelligence I call “quickness of apprehension”: the ability to rapidly recognize the importance of what one sees or hears. In a combat situation, this manifests in a highly intelligent creature's being able to read the room. It can tell a Life Domain cleric from a Light Domain cleric, a wizard from a sorcerer, or a fighter from a paladin. It can get a sense of a character's abilities by observing the force of their weapon strikes, watching them dodge attacks and take hits, and listening to them call out to their allies. It notes who's got magical weapons and what they do, pays attention to how badly injured its opponents are, observes the opponents' positioning, notices when someone has made a blunder, and capitalizes on it.

If a monster possesses superhuman intelligence, it's so perspicacious that it can glean precise information about an opponent's abilities at a mere glance, as if it were reading the opponent's character sheet or stat block. In other words, you as the DM can let it know anything and everything you know, as long as it could know these things by some plausible information vector—and then share this uncanny knowledge as a power move.

This Isn't What I Wanted

Aside from zealots, compulsion-driven undead creatures, and automata carrying out commands, it makes very little sense for most monsters and NPCs to fight to the death. In fact, opportunistic predators are likely to abandon combat immediately after taking one good wallop; they don't like it when prey fights back. Every monster or NPC belligerent enough to start a fight but not so ideologically committed to it that it would rather die than lose has a point at which it will call a truce and try to talk things out, run to get help, or flee the scene altogether, the first being most likely if it's a leader or solo creature with high Wisdom or Charisma (and, of course, the power of speech).

When a monster or NPC stops fighting to parley, look for one or more social skills among its skill proficiencies: These will tell you whether it prefers to bluster and threaten (Intimidation), negotiate in good faith (Persuasion), or lie through its teeth (Deception). If it's not proficient in any of these skills, you can have it try any or all of them, abandoning each one as soon as it stops working and switching to another.

An aspect of GMing that's always delighted me is information asymmetry. A creature has to make decisions on the basis of what it knows; it can't act on knowledge it doesn't have. Every discrepancy between what PCs know and what a monster or NPC knows creates an opening for trickery. If your creature has the informational advantage, have it pull a fast one on the PCs; if the PCs have it, let your creature be duped.

As you play out parley scenes, always remember what the creature's foremost interests are. These interests include not just its current survival but also its future survival, which may involve keeping a more powerful member of its kind happy, which in turn may entail completing a particular mission successfully. It may be charged with guarding something or someone, defending its territory from trespassers, or returning with information; it may simply be looking for food. Allow the situation to resolve itself if both sides can get what they want. On the other hand, if it becomes clear that the PCs aren't going to give the monster or NPC what it wants, have it resume fighting—or run.

Depending on how it goes, combat can even offer the greatest roleplaying opportunity of all: a villain or hero's dying words. Most GMs consider a defeated foe to be dead, but you can let one live just long enough to gasp out a scrap of vital information (or, tantalizingly, half of one), a final prayer, an apology, an expression of confusion, or a parting insult. As for players, when your PC is on the threshold, it's time to prepare yourself to deliver their final farewell. Look first to their bonds or ideals; if a reference to one of those doesn't feel right, maybe they have something urgent to say regarding the current situation, or maybe they simply want to bid their comrades farewell. Whatever you choose, ask your GM to let your PC speak their last words before expiring. Their story may be ending sooner than you'd hoped, but roleplaying their departure from the material world can at least give it a suitable and satisfying conclusion.

RPGS ARE RPG IF YOU RPG:

**Roleplaying Games are Really Pretty Great if
You Remember, Prepare, & Go (With the Flow)**

Clint McElroy

Beeb the Vampire Rogue was in a tough spot.

For the most part, the dagger wound in her left shoulder had stopped bleeding, but she wasn't sure it would take the strain if she were to try the jump from the chamber balcony to the window of the manor house across from her.

Staying put was not an option, since, well, the chamber was on fire.

"At that moment," says the GM across the table "the door to the chamber bursts open and the very hacked-off Magistrate levels a crossbow at you. What do you do?"

Beeb thinks for a moment and then responds:

What's my motivation?"

The Venn diagram of roleplaying and acting has a very large common area.

"Oh, thank you, Clint," you say with a sarcastic sneer in your voice.

"Comparing roleplaying with . . . *playing a role*! Let us go ahead and get that Nobel Prize for Literature all ready for you!"

To take it one step further, the Venn diagram of people who think they don't know how to roleplay and people who think they don't know how to act would have a similar common crossover. I believe both can be learned using a lot of the same techniques and tools.

“Clint, I know you are a beloved roleplaying podcaster, author, and dare-I-say idol to millions,” you say, not so much sarcastically, but . . . intrigued. “But are you qualified to instruct me in acting?”

I sure hope so, otherwise Marshall University pissed away all that money they paid me for ten years to teach the subject.

So now that I have so cleverly presented my bona fides, let’s get on with it.

Analyze This (or That)

You are taking on a character, putting it on like a costume (which we cover more literally later). One of the joys of roleplaying is being someone other than yourself. That’s not to say there’s anything wrong with being you, but you’re going to be delighted with how much fun it is to inhabit someone else. But you have to know this character, and a character analysis is a good starting point.

When an actor does a character analysis, it includes three temporal states:

1. **Before.** What has happened to the character *before* the story?
2. **During.** What happens *during* that story?
3. **After.** What will happen to the character *after* the story?

An actor determines the first and second part by analyzing the script. What does the character say about themselves? What do other characters say about them? What does the author say about them? There may be descriptions of how the character appears, how they talk, move. The third point (what will happen after) may sound silly since it may not be canon, but it can be a good example of how well an actor knows their character.

Of course, in an RPG, there is no script. The “Before” part of your preparation will be in how you want the character to look, feel, act. Go into as much detail as you can. The more you know about your Halfling Techno Assassin, the better you will know how to make decisions for them. The “During” and “After” will be determined by you, your fellow players, and your GM.

Memories Bring You Back

Ever smell popcorn and remember the time your parents took you to see *Rogue One*? Ever hear a song and flashback to your first slow dance? You probably haven’t thought about those things for a very long time. That’s Sense Memory. Your remarkable brain—Hercules Poirot’s “little grey cells”—has kajillions of memories stored in it. And they are tied to what you sensed at the time. What you saw, heard, tasted, felt, and smelled can open the cerebral expressway to a specific time in your life. Using sense memory, you can remember your emotions at that time. The pleasure you experienced

when you yummied out on that popcorn watching Jyn Erso mow down Stormtroopers or that sweet awkwardness of the first slow dance.

Acting is really reacting. And how you reacted to situations in your past, how you felt, can guide you in making decisions about what to do while roleplaying.

The Voice

It's very important that you hit the button and make your chair spin around as soon as you think the singer is someone you want on your team.

Oh, wait, sorry, that was my advice for Blake Shelton.

Doing a character voice is certainly not mandatory. But, like these other techniques, if it helps you get into character, do it! Try an accent. Take your voice down an octave or up an octave. Try something guttural or sweet. Don't do anything that's going to strain your voice or will be difficult to maintain. And *don't, don't, don't* do a voice that might be insensitive or offensive to your table mates. Doing a voice also comes in very handy when you are differentiating between what *player you* is saying and what *character you* is saying.

Want a good starting point? Imitate someone. Someone you know. Someone famous. Everybody does imitations. And if you think T'Dot the Halfling Techno Assassin sounds like your Uncle Tad from Michigan and that helps you take on the character, then "G'wan, ya Yooper!"

The beauty of it? If it's not working . . . you can stop.

Evening (or Morning or Afternoon) at the Improv

Aidyl the Goblin Catburglar says: "I open the window to the manor house and throw the weighted end of my climbing rope toward Beeb on the chamber balcony."

Beeb follows that with, "Yes, and I catch the rope and tie it off on the balcony rail."

Eilrahc the Cyborg Dancer says, "Yes, and I get ready to catch her when she slides down the rope!"

Sug the Golem Cleric adds, "Yes, and I get ready to cast a healing spell."

I don't want to go all Captain Obvious here, but improvisation is the essence of RPGs. You, your fellow players, and your GM really are "making this up as we go along." This might be the most intimidating aspect of RPGs to new players. I get it. I play a weekly game with three of the funniest, most creative people I know: my sons. I have to stay on my toes. But here are some tools to help you improvise.

- **Listen.** Pay attention to the other people around the table. Really listen. Take in what they are doing. It will shape what you should do in the moment.
- **Be Flexible.** If you are locked in on what you're going to do next or say next, then you aren't really listening and you are not being a good collaborator. Unless you're one of the PreCogs from *Minority Report*, you don't know what's coming next. That's not to say you can't make plans or have an idea what you want to do next, but you have to be ready to pivot if things take a turn you hadn't anticipated.
- **"Yes, And . . ."** is one of the most important parts of improvisation. It means you do a good job listening and responding to what the other improviser says and expanding on what they said.

Clothes Make the Centaur

Wearing a costume is along the same lines as doing a voice: If it helps you get into character, you should do it. Putting on a costume can be very liberating. It's one of acting's alchemical effects. Remember when you wore that really cool Power Rangers costume for Trick or Treat? Remember the sense of freedom you had? Remember the smell of the inside of that mask after about an hour? (Sense memory strikes again!)

You are not playing yourself in this game. You are someone else. And a costume can help you be that someone else.

One Caveat: Check with your GM and other players beforehand. You don't want Repooc the Centaur to feel left out because the rest of the group is in cosplay, and she showed up in her Pink hoodie and cargo shorts.

Why So Serious?

Enjoy yourself, for cryin' out loud. Don't be worried that you're going to do the wrong thing. There *is* no wrong thing. There are just "different" things. The bottom line is, everybody is there for the same purpose: to have a good time. The only thing wrong with people is that they are people. Everybody has their little foibles, quirks, and peccadilloes, but trust your GM to manage the game and make sure nobody hogs too much of the action. And yes . . . I wrote that sentence only so I could use the word "peccadilloes."

Don't focus so much on the RP part that you forget the G part.

Beeb slides down Aidyl's rope into the waiting arms of Eilrahc. Sug heals her shoulder as Ryhen the Were-Hedgehog grins, holding open his pack to reveal the five thousand gold pieces they just absconded with from the Magistrate . . . which explains why he was so hacked off.

"Ahhhhh," says Beeb. "There's my motivation!"

STEPPING INTO CHARACTER:

Level Up Your Roleplaying

Luke Gyga

Roleplaying is not just a game; it's a creative outlet, a chance to weave epic tales, and an opportunity to step into another pair of shoes, boots, or maybe even bare feet, depending on the choices you make when breathing life into a character. I am the son of E. Gary Gyga, the co-creator of *Dungeons and Dragons*, and the Father of Roleplaying Games. I have literally been playing RPGs for as long as I can remember. I'm Patient Zero for being raised on RPGs. With this pedigree and experience you might assume that I am a master at gaming, but that isn't the case. The game keeps evolving and changes with new rules, and most importantly, new styles of play.

When I first began playing RPGs, the game focused mainly on exploration and combat. There were times when you would roleplay, but it would typically be a brief interlude and wasn't usually central to the game—like, you might talk to your mentor and negotiate how much training to level up would cost. Most sessions consisted of a band of heroes descending into a subterranean labyrinth to explore a maze of tunnels and rooms housing a host of horrible creatures. Part of the challenge for the players was accurately mapping the dungeon so you could spot areas where a room could be and search for secret doors. The GM might throw a curveball at you and have a teleporter or passages sloping under the caverns and corridors. This would cause great consternation and concern to the person mapping, as they couldn't be sure if they had made an error.

Over time, the dungeon-crawl style of play began to evolve. As RPGs matured, roleplaying expanded as players began to explore characters in depth, and storytelling became more robust. Storytelling is a fundamental part of being human. It's a way for us to share information that connects with us at an emotional level and creates bonds. Today, players expect an intersection of story and roleplaying to create immersive experiences that engage them on emotional and cognitive levels. They want characters, plotlines, and settings to interact in ways that allow them to impact the story's progression and the outcome.

Player-driven narrative engagement is entertaining and fosters critical thinking, empathy, and creativity. Players get to explore different perspectives, make strategic decisions, and navigate complex social interactions, all within the confines of the game's universe. Managing to put all this together can be daunting for a GM. However, this is *shared storytelling*, and it becomes both easier and a better experience for everyone if the players embrace their characters. Sometimes that can be challenging for players—but with a little forethought and practice, everyone can up their game.

As a longtime player and RPG aficionado, I have a few strategies to elevate your game play. I run games at conventions for groups of players who haven't gelled as a team yet, and I live play streaming events with an audience to entertain. These experiences are a crucible where you test your capabilities. You can quickly tell whether something works or not in these environments, and I feel that my skills improved rapidly through these experiences. I'd like you, dear reader, to gain from my experience without having to go through the repetitions or suffer from the missteps I most certainly made over the years. You can use these techniques as a player and a GM with equal efficacy.

Understand Your Character

This sounds like a simple concept, and it is generally straightforward. You should understand your character's backstory, traits, motivations, and goals so you can react to situations as your character would respond. Every character has a unique personality and history, and embodying this will make your roleplaying more believable and engaging. Immersing yourself in your character helps you better understand their motivations, fears, and talents. I've found that when I give players just one or two paragraphs of backstory detailing something about their past, why they are where they are now, and what they want to accomplish in the future, they quickly assume that character's persona. Everyone pulls out different facets of the story and

makes it their own. It has enhanced my convention one-shots immensely, especially when I weave various characters backstories together so they have trusted friends, rivals, and perhaps even tension between others.

Engage with the Story and World

RPGs are interactive storytelling games. As a player, you should engage with the storyline and the world the GM has created. Make sure you ask questions, explore, and let your character interact with the environment and other characters, both player and non-player (NPCs). This will not only enrich your gaming experience but will also help you contribute to the shared narrative. I help this along by establishing relationships with the characters in a convention one-shot. If you are starting a campaign, then look to shape things during your session zero.

Communicate In-Character

This can feel awkward for new players, but it's an essential facet of immersing yourself in the game. Players should speak and act as their character when they are interacting with others during the game. It's fine to break character to ask clarification on details from the GM, but then you should get back into character and behave as your character. This doesn't mean you need to put on a theatrical performance. Simply embodying your character's speech and mannerisms can greatly enhance your roleplaying.

However, I would encourage you to try to use voices for your characters, especially as the GM. Learning how to use your voice effectively can enhance the players' experience and greatly aid immersion in the game. I resisted using voices for years before deciding that, despite my lack of aptitude, I should endeavor to employ them. I won't lie to you and say I am completely comfortable using voices or that I am good at it. I can say that no one has given me any negative feedback about this, and I feel like I convey the character to the players more effectively by using the voice, affecting a manner of speech and diction.

There are some good online resources to help you hone your skills. You can also record yourself to privately assess your prowess. I will try out new voices by talking to my dog, Grogu, until it sounds right to myself, and then progress to using it with my daughters to get their feedback. The takeaway from this is, like Nike says: Just do it.

Collaborate with Fellow Players

RPGs are a team sport! Collaboration with your fellow players to overcome obstacles is central to the game. Your interactions with each other and the NPCs build the story. Other players are a great source of inspiration, and ideally you form a synergy at the table that enhances everyone's roleplay. You should always be respectful of the others in your game, even if something doesn't work out as well as they hoped it would.

Respect the Game Environment

Respect is a core value that every one of us deserves when we are playing together, and it will allow others to be more adventurous in their roleplay. This applies not only to interactions with your fellow players, but to your GM too. Putting together a campaign is a lot of work, and the GM has likely spent a significant amount of time crafting the scenario and setting up any terrain and/or props. Avoid taking actions that might disrupt the overall plot or make the game less enjoyable for others. It may be fun for you to play the chaotic neutral rogue who does whatever they want, whenever they want to do it. However, it's good to remember that there are others involved. If your character is a chaos goblin, make sure to get the GM's buy-in before you do something that might derail the plot.

Maintain the Balance of Gameplay and Roleplay

It's right there in the title: roleplaying game. Certainly, the RP is integral to the game, but it is not theater. Maintaining a good balance between the "game" aspects and the "roleplay" will help make the game session enjoyable for all. A big part of the joy of gaming is rolling the dice during combat, solving puzzles, and all the other crunchy bits that make up a great experience at the gaming table.

Experiment with Different Characters

RPGs offer many different ways to build a wide variety of characters, each providing different experiences. Don't be afraid to step out of your comfort zone and try new characters. This will lead you to discover new strategies, thinking about situations in a different way, and to experience interactions that can enhance your roleplaying experience, as well as that of others in the group. Some of the most entertaining sessions I've had were when I played a character who was decidedly different than expected, such as my *Top Secret* spy character who barely knew how to use a firearm, or my superhero who looked and acted more like a professional bowler.

They served as a counterpoint to the other characters and gave me the opportunity to have unanticipated exchanges with other players that were quite entertaining. Their priorities were different than most of the group, so we came up with different ways to approach challenges.

Progress Your Character

Leveling up is a feature of RPGs that sets it aside from other genres. You should be looking for opportunities to improve your character—as your campaign progresses, your character should also grow. This can be via gaining new skills or abilities, or it can be through character development. This might involve your character's personal growth, such as overcoming fears or achieving personal goals. Change is inevitable.

Reflect and Learn

Finally, reflecting on your roleplaying experiences can help improve your skills. Take note of what worked well, what didn't pan out, and learn from your experiences. Roleplaying is a skill that you can train and improve like any other skill. I found watching live streams to be a great way to grow. Try recording yourself, playing it back, and critiquing your performance. I'd be shocked if that doesn't lead to significant growth in your RP skills.

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In conclusion, improving your roleplaying involves understanding your character, engaging with the game world, speaking in-character, collaborating with fellow players, and learning from your experiences. A cooperative and supportive roleplayer will enhance game play for everyone. By following these techniques, you'll certainly enhance your roleplaying skills and maximize your enjoyment of the fantastic RPG genre.

²Such as YouTube videos “EASY Voice Acting Techniques for RPG Characters” and “More EASY voice acting tips for your TTRPG character” by Lunch Break Heroes and “How to Create 100 Distinctly Different Voices” by Improve Your Voice.

THE HIDDEN E IN RPG:

Using Empathy to Improve Your Roleplay

Rajan Khanna

I've been playing TTRPGs for about forty years, and I can say without hesitation that what keeps me coming back is the RP in RPG. Roleplaying is what sets TTRPGs apart from all other games—the ability to assume the role of someone other than yourself and determine how they act and feel and respond. Like actors, TTRPG players immerse themselves in the life of another person, but unlike actors, TTRPG players don't have to stick to a script.

In a time when actual play podcasts and streams are so popular, some players (or aspiring players) might feel pressure to play each character like an experienced actor, complete with accents and pithy dialogue. GMs might feel the need to be vocal chameleons like Matt Mercer of *Critical Role*. This can, of course, be fun, but people should play TTRPGs the way they want—in a manner they're comfortable with (and others in their game are comfortable with), and in a way that makes them happy. There is a spectrum of roleplaying and every spot on that spectrum is valid. However, straying from your comfort zone can not only be fun, but it can help you grow as a person.

The essence of roleplaying a character is putting yourself in that character's shoes, imagining what they would be like as a living, breathing person, extrapolating their concept and backstory into a life. In the process, a fictional person is built from a synthesis of character history, ancestry, and setting. That person may start as just a sketch, a few personality traits and tics, but the more you play that character, the more fully realized they become.

I learned how to roleplay, to *really* roleplay, while I was at university. There, I created a character named Andor (long before the television show of the same name), a half-elf ranger in a largely traditional but low-magic fantasy world. When I started playing him, I only knew a few details. He grew up with his mother in the woods and never knew his father. His mother had fled her town for a solitary life in the forest, and Andor's youth in the forest taught him the ranger skills he would have later in life. Years later, when hobgoblins killed his mother, he hunted down the tribe that did it for revenge, an explanation for his favored enemy. That seemed a good start for the character.

The GM of that game fully expected the RP in RPG to be present in his game. He invited and encouraged the players to play fully in character during our sessions. He frowned on "out of game speak" at the table. It was a stricter approach than I would take as GM, but at the time I felt the need to rise to the challenge. When I started to roleplay my character as well as I could, it forced me to really put myself in Andor's boots, forced me to imagine how he would see the world. Andor grew up far from civilization and far from other people and with the knowledge that his mother hadn't been treated well by her former neighbors, so it made sense that he was uncomfortable in towns and would be slow to trust others. I also decided that he valued a person's actions over their words, since words could easily deceive. If you proved your worth to him through your actions, he would accept you. Because of what happened to his mother, he believed strongly in justice and righting wrongs, but he cared little for laws and rules that obfuscated such concepts. It was more than enough to start forming his personality.

The roleplaying was enriched further by new situations and interesting circumstances in the game. When something happened, I had another acronym to consider—WWAD. What Would Andor Do? Each time this question was asked and answered, Andor's personality grew . . . and sometimes changed. After time spent in a nearby town, for example, the friendships he formed there helped soften his views of civilization and its injustices. Then there was the time later in his career when he encountered a group of young hobgoblins—his sworn enemy; on paper he hated hobgoblins, and probably could have seen them as future threats, but when I tapped into the character, in that situation, I knew he had to let them go. I knew that in knowing he had killed these young hobgoblins' parents (which he did), he would see a mirrored version of his own childhood, and the cycle of vengeance that that could spur. It didn't mean he stopped hating hobgoblins, but it added another dimension to his feelings about them, and another layer to his character. I even imagined he would still feel conflicted about it afterward, wondering if he had made the right decision, wondering what mayhem those hobgoblins may have caused.

Even later still, he lost a battle and (in a rather severe aftermath), one of his eyes was put out and one of his arms chopped off. I was suitably morose afterward, and so was he, but it became easier to accept when I saw it as a roleplaying opportunity. In some ways, in the game, Andor was limited by these injuries, but there was more to roleplay with. So he went emo for a while, then bitter and angry, then finally began to accept what had happened and move on with his life (and fortunately, he was eventually able to replace the arm with a magical one).

I played that character for years, sometimes as a party of one, and he developed and grew more than any character I've ever played in a TTRPG, or even written about in fiction. But aside from being fun, and teaching me how to roleplay, that experience accomplished even more. It helped me develop a stronger sense of empathy.

Empathy can be loosely defined as the ability to understand and inhabit the point of view of another person, to see their perspective, feel their feelings. This is the essence of roleplaying a TTRPG character, and yet it is also one of the fundamental ways to relate to other human beings in our real lives. Understanding another person's experience, and how they feel, not only breaks down barriers between people, but it is the basis for stronger connections and a key factor in combating bigotry and racism, of overcoming divisions based on class, religion, gender, race, culture, and more. The same practice that lets you play your TTRPG character better helps you connect more intensely and intimately to other humans in the real world.

Will roleplaying change the world? Maybe not. But using those skills, imagining another person's life, imagining how they think and feel, imagining yourself in their shoes, can help develop your ability to do that in real life.

The GM who ran the game where I played Andor was someone I went to university with. I knew, like me, he was into fantasy books and TTRPGs and so early on in our acquaintance I asked him about it, hoping to explore common ground. To my surprise, he was gruff and almost belligerent to me in response. I figured he was a jerk and, despite our shared interests, not worth my time. But then I imagined things from his perspective. At the time, fantasy fiction and TTRPGs weren't always respected by the mainstream. He was an open and unapologetic nerd, but I imagined that many of the people who asked about his hobbies did so to make fun of them. So he was expecting more of the same. When I realized that, I let go of my own defensiveness and worked on slowly showing him that I appreciated his interests and shared them. It led to one of the strongest friendships of my life. And it wouldn't have happened if I wasn't able to break out of my own point of view and try to imagine his.

So when you roleplay, I urge you to really put yourself in your character's shoes, to try and think and feel like they do. Try to play characters that are as different from you as possible. Characters of different gender identities, races, species, backgrounds. See what it feels like and what you learn. Liberate yourself from your own experience. Then use that same ability on people that you encounter in your life, people who are different from you. I'm not saying to treat them like a TTRPG character—they are living, breathing people, after all—but use those RP skills to try to understand them better. Talk to them. Learn about their lives, their backgrounds, and imagine how that shaped them.

These skills have other applications, too. Later, at the same university, my girlfriend at the time was auditioning for a play. While helping her practice, I realized it wasn't much different from roleplaying. It was even a bit easier since there was a script. I tried out and got a decent part despite no acting experience. Even later still, these skills were invaluable when I started writing fiction. If you want the characters you write about to be as vivid as possible, imagining them and their lives as fully as you can will infuse more life into them.

Obviously, I believe in the power of empathy in real life too, the way it can bring people closer and break down barriers. But empathy alone is not enough. Empathy is not the end of the process, but the beginning. Empathy is a process in your mind, a changing of your perspective. If you come to an understanding of someone and their experience—and then just carry on with your life, only you have changed. Changing the world, helping to address divisions and hostility and injustice, powerful change, requires action. It requires taking the next step once you've had your change in perspective. Maybe that step is forming a connection, maybe it's sharing what you learned. Maybe it's working against the inequalities you just started to understand. That part can often be harder. But take inspiration from your characters who changed their world for the better and use the skills you learned playing them to try to make the real world a better place too.

YES, AND . . . NOW YOU'RE ON FIRE!

Applying Improv Theory to Your RPG Roleplay

Curtis C. Chen

David Damphouse (pronounced /dah-VEED dahm-FOOS/) is a Dwarf Druid. As a baby, he was adopted by upper-class human parents who gave him a hoity-toity name. When David came of age, he went out into the world to seek his fortune, adventuring with a motley crew around the Columbia Colonies (a homebrew setting created by my wife, the GM). His companions frequently made fun of his French accent, his jaunty beret, and his constant cigarette smoking, but David didn't let any of that keep him from living his best life.

He eventually reached level 16, gaining a vast array of impressive Druidic powers, including the ability to turn into a dinosaur. After being named a "hero of the colony," David entered local politics and was elected governor by running on the platform, "Fire Bad, Bacon Good" (it's a long story, you kinda had to be there). And that was the very satisfying end of our multi-year D&D campaign!

Now, I didn't come up with all that backstory immediately, and some of the most entertaining character bits developed over many sessions, as David interacted with the other player characters, and they all encountered various challenges as a team. It was the first long-term D&D group I'd ever been involved in, and I learned a lot about my preferred play style, which is basically just improv comedy.

I've never done actual improv on stage myself, but I have been performing in public for many years (acting, singing, speaking at author events), and I've always had an affinity for comedy—as a young immigrant to the US, I grew up learning about American culture largely from TV sitcoms, for better or worse. (I also watched a lot of Monty Python—thanks PBS!—but that's another essay.) My Kangaroo novels are known for their humor, and honestly, any time I'm presenting a workshop or paneling at a con, my main goal is to get a laugh. Because that's how I know people are paying attention to what I'm saying. Not just listening, but really hearing and understanding the content—because you don't laugh if you don't get the joke.

And the flip side of that is knowing the right joke to tell to a specific audience—“reading the room,” as professional comics say. At the most basic level, it's an awareness of whether the people around you will get the reference you're making. (Have they all seen the *Honor Among Thieves* movie? Do they also remember that Chris Pine played Captain Kirk in those Abramsverse *Star Trek* flicks? If you're not sure, maybe skip that joke about him kissing everything in sight; it's not going to land. Make fun of his hair instead. Or, you know, just leave Chris Pine alone. He's doing his best out there.)

Here's the best part about gaming, though: Everyone's there to have fun. You're both audience and performer, and that opens up countless possibilities for everyone to support each other. RPGs are not competitive. They're collaborative storytelling. That's why your adventuring party is at its best when it includes different classes and races. In the same way that every player character can have different abilities and powers, every player can be entertaining in a different way and contribute something unique to the story you're all building together.

For example, when playing David Damphouse (again, pronounced /dah-VEED dahm-FOOS/), I frequently consulted my fellow players when leveling up and choosing new powers. I might not have chosen the dinosaur form without their input, and that turned out to be a great decision for this particular group. With a different bunch of people, I might have made different choices—not better or worse, just different. And as long as we were all committed to having fun together, it would still have been a good time.

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And now is the time in this essay when I compare RPGs to a television writers' room. Remember how it's all collaborative storytelling? David Damphouse obviously did not want to be set on fire at any point in his life, but everyone at our table (led by the GM) agreed that it was, in fact, the

most interesting problem for him to have at that point in that particular session. And the rest of the party had his back, so you know, it all worked out in the end. I mean, he's governor now. All the bacon he can eat and every room is a smoking room. Top of the world, *maman!*

I recently served as head writer for the Realm podcast series *Echo Park*, leading a team of four other writers to script a science fiction thriller involving clones that was narrated in its final form by Harry Shum Jr. I'd worked on two other series for Realm previously, but this was the first one where I was in charge of guiding the creative vision, and it's fair to say that it felt a lot like what I've seen my wife do when she runs an RPG. It wasn't my job as lead writer to come up with every idea in the room; it was my job to provide a good framework for everyone to work together and build on each other's creativity to make the best story we could together.

So how do the players and the GM work together, without spelling out some kind of explicit agreement? Well, sometimes doing that's not a bad idea. But usually, it's just about paying attention to the other people around the table, caring about what they want, and figuring out the most interesting way to get from point A to point B.

Working on *Echo Park*, I was sure to make room for folks to spin out off-the-wall notions so we could all see if it would lead to a better story. As a roleplayer in various games, I've seen a variety of GMs working in different ways to notice their players' unspoken wants and wishes and modify a session's challenges to match. It's usually the case, in my experience, that letting the whole table (or room) talk through a plot point yields better results than the GM (or lead writer) deciding unilaterally what you're all going to do next.

It's really all about collaboration, in the end. Remember in kindergarten, when the adults would encourage you to "play well with others"? Well, that wasn't just so you'd be able to function in a world full of other grown-ups who disagree with your opinions on a million different things, from pizza toppings to health care reform; that also turns out to be the key to having a rich and fulfilling social life, which (as we all ought to know, post-pandemic lockdowns) is essential to the human experience.

The key concept underlying all improv theater is "yes, and." You never naysay a scene partner's idea of what will happen next, no matter how outlandish. If they propose that you've just stumbled across a magical cave full of glittering doll-heads, your job is to say "yes, and," and append your own wild idea after that. In live improv, it's less about coming up with a great idea on the spot and more about following your instincts and trusting

your scene partner(s) to keep building on each successive notion, no matter where it leads, with the understanding that you're all trying to keep things from going too far off the rails.

The same applies in RPGs. Maybe the stated goal of the encounter is to slay a monster. Or perhaps it's to find some kid who's gotten lost down a lava tube. (Shouldn't this town have, I don't know, emergency services that take care of this sort of thing, instead of the parents having to hire a bunch of wanderers who just happen to be in the tavern that night?) Don't worry about that right now. "Yes, and . . . what's the reward for this?" ("You mean other than being ethical adventurers?" "Hey, we don't know this kid, he could be a jerk." And so on. Your group may have different ideas about social responsibility in fantasy settings, but that is also another essay.)

In the course of the rescue, does someone want to use a highly impractical magic spell they very recently learned so they can levitate into the lava tube, instead of just using that fifty feet of rope that someone else has been hauling around forever? Sure, let's go with that; she really wants to cast that spell. Does someone want to also send their untrained companion animal down there to run around unsupervised? Sounds like a terrible idea. Let's do it and see what happens!

Above all, remember: You are not the character. You, the player, are in charge of creating the most interesting story for your character, in collaboration with everyone else at the table. "Yes, and" at its best is a relay race, where one person's creativity hands off to another person's distinct point of view on the evolving situation, and every new plot twist adds to everyone's enjoyment of the story at large. The only wrong way to do improv is to stop the fun train.

Improv comedy for the win, friends! Be willing to set your character on fire to get a laugh. Or turn him into a dinosaur. You know, read the room. But just say yes! No regrets!

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This message was approved by Governor David Damphouse of the Columbia Colonies while in his non-dinosaur form.

ROLEPLAYING “THE GAME MASTER”:

Getting into Character As GM

Sharang Biswas

In my early days in NYC, I was invited to run a mini-campaign of *Curse of Strahd*, the well-known *Dungeons & Dragons* horror adventure, at the 20-Sided Store in Brooklyn. I was a fairly new GM back then, but I wanted to experiment. So I donned an all-black wardrobe with excessive amounts of eyeliner, bought myself a pair of cheap, white gloves to which I added an extra drop of scarlet food-colouring each week, and endeavoured to slowly enunciate every syllable I spoke, edging each word with a sarcastic, arrogant trim. When players asked me a question, I would pause a second or two longer than necessary while looking them straight in the eye before answering. I practiced a sinister smile, and if players made a choice that they knew was ridiculous, I would raise an eyebrow or smirk before proceeding.

The effect was electric. Players were riveted. Some players wondered if I was embodying the legendary vampire lord Strahd himself. Others thought that the personality I had put on was my own personality and were shocked when they encountered me in colourful clothing and a more welcoming demeanour at other games at the store. My now close friend and collaborator Lucian Kahn told people that he was “playing D&D led by this weird, gay goth.” I’m still gay, but I’m a slightly different breed of weird—and goth I have never been.

Since then, I've used this technique—of embodying my own character as a game master—a few times, notably when running Whitney Beltrán, Sarah Richardson, and Marissa Kelly's excellent feminist/feminine horror game *Bluebeard's Bride*. In fact, *Bluebeard's Bride's* rules expect GMs to do this sort of thing in order to better immerse the players in the themes of misogyny and societal violence against women that the game explores: "Once, you were the one to learn proper, ladylike behaviour," the game tells you in the chapter about how to run the game. "Now you will teach this lesson. Once, you were the one to entertain the careless whims of me. Now, you will share this wisdom."

Of course, this technique is not for everyone or every game. Your players may prefer to speak to you as their friend, separating you from the game. You might find it exhausting to get into character while juggling different game mechanics. You might just think it's irritating. That's totally understandable! This is just one tool for your arsenal of GM techniques. Maybe you'll use it all the time. Maybe you'll only use it for a particular game, for particular genres of games, or for one-shots. Maybe you'll take only pieces of what I suggest and incorporate them into your own unique style. Or maybe you'll never use what I suggest and treat this essay as an interesting, theoretical exercise!

The heart of what I'm suggesting is this: as a GM, give yourself a character. Ultimately, this will alter how you respond to players and how you narrate and describe scenes, giving your game a feel that's very different from if you were just running a game as yourself.

Here are a few ways you can put this into practice.

Concept

Have a clear concept for who you're playing as a GM. "Clear" doesn't necessarily mean "fully fleshed out." You don't need a whole backstory or a list of traits. *Bluebeard's Bride* tells you that you're the groundskeeper, that you're a bit of a misogynist, and that you really want the players (who collectively play the "Bride") to become better wives and women. When I run John Harper's game of supernatural criminal gangs *Blades in the Dark*, I sometimes style myself as "Chillington," a posh, arrogant, and judgmental servant to the crew's wealthy, mysterious patron. Having a clear concept will help you respond better to your players in-character.

Physicality

Think about an identifiable tic or habit, but only if it adds to the tone of the game. If you've decided to play a timid news reporter as GM, nervous hand rubbing might be great for a game where you want your players to feel like larger-than-life superheroes. Uncanny head tilts and knowing stares might up the strangeness for a game of weird horror where you embody a mysterious cultist.

Diegetic Introductions

Introduce the game diegetically—that is, from within the created world of the story. This lets you bring your players into the game straight from the start. When I run Monte Cook's science-fantasy game *Numenera*—set a billion years in the future on an Earth that has seen multiple human civilizations, alien invasion, and transdimensional incursions—I always introduce the basic premise of the game as a story told to the characters around a campfire: “They say this is the Ninth World, after eight separate civilizations of people fell. Look: do you see those mountains? Stories say they're actually giant automatons, buried under a thin layer of dirt. . . .” When I've run *Blades in the Dark*, I've sometimes asked players to pick from my set of pregenerated characters by going, “So my employer needs to know what kind of skills each of you have. Are you a Whisper—an arcane adept and channeler of strange forces? He really likes working with those kinds of guys. Or are you a Lurk—a stealthy . . .”

Commentary

Comment on the characters' actions. In your persona's opinion, are they doing a good job? Are they bungling up? Are they being reckless? “My master seems to have finally picked a good team!” or “Why does my employer bother with hiring riffraff like this?” might be fun things to say at the table. Keep in mind the tone of the game. You don't want to be overly critical in a game where players are supposed to feel powerful and competent, for instance. And remember, criticizing a character and criticizing a player are different things. You want to do the former but avoid the latter.

Addressing Players

Vary how you address the players. Get up and pace to suggest that you're thinking deeply or that you're agitated. Whisper things into players' ears. Take their hand, look them in the eye, and tell them matter-of-factly that they need to make a roll to resist the terrible poison they just ingested. Tear up a handout while telling the players how terrible the consequences for

their actions will be. Changing up your physicality is a great way to engage players. Just make sure you have a table that's comfortable with that kind of thing. (Ask at the start if it's okay to touch your players, for example.)

Portraying NPCs

Playing a character as a GM doesn't mean you can't portray NPCs too. In fact, the abrupt shift from your GM persona to an NPC might create interesting effects in some cases. And note that accents, the beloved tactic of game masters everywhere, aren't the only way to bring NPCs to life. If you're focusing on changing the way you speak, you can think about altering dialect, word usage, volume, speech speed, and rhythm. An excited academic might speak very quickly and use complex syntactical structures, while a scared young girl might speak softly and haltingly. But the voice isn't your sole tool: Don't be afraid to flex your larping skills. Don't say, "... she kneels down and takes your hand, imploring you to help." Actually do so! Pull the players into the scene! Quick warning, though: I recommend this more for drama scenes than for fights. In crunchy games, you might slow down combat through the overuse of this technique.

Your Role

Remember that you're still a GM and that your role as teacher and keeper of rules hasn't vanished. You're still responsible for clarity, brevity, and kindness in how you inform players about the game mechanics and rules. However, you can do so in character! Comments could help here: "I don't know why I have to teach you these things; you're supposed to be the experts!"; "Oh yes, you might not have used this equipment in your previous job; let me show you. . . ." Just remember not to insult your players for not knowing the rules, but it's probably okay to insult the *characters*. (See my fourth point!)

Extras

Think about costuming. This is perhaps the least important suggestion I'll give you, since tabletop games are all about the theatre of the mind, and players can easily manage without externalities. Nevertheless, some thought into costuming can definitely affect the tone of a game. Wearing all black or a rainbow suit will absolutely make players see you differently, for instance. Makeup, jewellery, or an unusual hair style can all be used to help create a persona. This sort of thing isn't limited to what you wear, of course. Props, player handouts, and the like can help achieve a similar effect.

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These techniques tend to work best for games with a strong aesthetic concept. Horror, mystery, and surreal games, as well as games where the players take on the role of extremely specific characters (such as the fanatical preacher-postmen in the wild west of Vincent Baker's *Dogs in the Vineyard*, a crew of desperate thugs in the haunted steampunk city of Harper's *Blades in the Dark*, the helpful shape-shifting animal spirits frolicking in the Japanese sunshine of Ryo Kamiya and Ewen Cluney's *Golden Sky Stories*) often benefit from these techniques.

I hope that some of these techniques will be of use to you as a game master. We all have our unique styles. Perhaps you can add to yours with these ideas from mine!

FROM MONOLOGUE TO DIALOGUE:

Roleplaying as a Storytelling Device

B. Dave Walters

In the infinite web of human experiences, storytelling stands alone as a sacred trust—a unique space where listeners and narrators bind themselves to the very essence of what it means to be human. The act of storytelling isn't just a casual exchange of words or an exercise in art; it's a covenant where reality meets imagination, where the intangible constructs of belief and culture are woven into concrete narratives. Within this sacred trust, roleplaying emerges as an evolved form of storytelling, a gallery where every player is both the artist and the canvas.

Yet the sacred nature of storytelling isn't just an abstract concept. It is storytelling that defines us as human beings. As to what makes storytelling an exclusively human activity, the answer might lie in the layers of complexity and abstract thought that our tales often contain. While animals communicate—warning of danger, signaling for mating—it's humanity's ability to convey not just information but also wisdom that sets us apart. Until we can comprehend the clicks of dolphins, the dances of bees, or the songs of whales as abstract concepts or life lessons, humans remain unique. As it stands, we're the only creatures capable of sitting around a fire, sharing legends, fables, and histories from which we can glean actionable insights into our lives. In that sense, storytelling isn't just what we do: it's who we are.

Roleplaying serves as a unique vessel for storytelling, filling it with qualities of immersion and personalization not found in any other medium. Within this unique framework, we are given the room to explore not just fantastical worlds, but also the uncharted and infinite territories of our own minds. The end result is a voyage that offers both narrative satisfaction and windows into self-discovery.

The Sacred Trust of Storytelling

The notion of storytelling as a “sacred trust” is one steeped in an almost mystical reverence for narratives stretching back to the dawn of time. From the primordial campfires where tribal shamans wove complex tapestries of myth and morals to the intricately engineered webs of today’s cinematic universes, storytelling remains a sort of covenant. It is a pact between the narrator and the audience, an unspoken agreement that the listener will be transported to a place they’ve never seen, and in return, offer their emotional investment, their willingness to suspend disbelief.

Historically, this sacred trust has acted as the bedrock upon which civilizations and their corresponding cultures were built. Whether through spoken words, chiseled tablets, inked manuscripts, or digital keystrokes, each story is a link in the chain of collective human consciousness. They serve as the keepers of tradition, the demonstrators of societal norms, and often as the questioners of those very norms, offering ethical dilemmas and moral conundrums that can change the zeitgeist for the better.

Roleplaying Fundamentals Across Genres

Roleplaying is not merely a pastime; it’s an extension of the very purpose of storytelling—just dressed in many different garbs. At its core, roleplaying involves adopting a persona separate from your own, often in a setting designed for a specific experience. Character creation is your passport into this narrative realm. You construct a character—complete with a backstory, personality traits, and skills—that you’ll navigate through a maze of trials, tribulations, and triumphs. This isn’t just make-believe; it’s an emotional investment. You’re putting on a mask, but in doing so, you’re revealing deeper, often unknown facets of your own self, testing your convictions, fears, and aspirations in a safe and supportive context.

And oh, the diversity of these contexts! Roleplaying thrives in various genres, each offering a different palette of emotional and intellectual experiences. In a fantasy setting, you’re likely combating dragons and solving ancient riddles, elements invoking courage and wit. Horror roleplay shifts the challenges into the sphere of resilience and survival, facing unfathomable fears that the dark corners of the human psyche reluctantly acknowledge, but doggedly try to hide. Psychological stories

dive deeper still, probing moral dilemmas and cerebral labyrinths that challenge not just what you think, but how you think, and perhaps who you really are.

The linchpin holding these divergent threads together is the game master. This individual is the maestro, the one tasked with not merely telling but orchestrating the story. Their role is a complex dance of preparation and improvisation. They construct the world, populate it with characters both friend and foe, and shape the plot's pacing and direction. Yet they must also adapt to the choices of the roleplayers, ensuring the world reacts in a way that's consistent and engaging, and above all else, elicits an emotional reaction from the players. In essence, they are the keepers of the sacred trust of storytelling, the burden and the privilege, and they are charged with translating it to the gaming table.

It's a symbiotic relationship—players and game masters, characters and stories, challenges and resolutions—all coalescing into a grand narrative ballet. This is roleplaying, and it's storytelling in its most interactive form.

The Mask We Wear: Character as a Vessel for Exploration

In the intricate tapestry of storytelling, roleplaying games introduce a golden thread: the concept of “wearing a mask,” or embodying a character. This practice transcends mere performance; it becomes a transformative lens through which we can step outside ourselves and view the world anew. Slipping into a character's skin, we assume a new persona, complete with its own desires, limitations, and moral complexities. This character serves as a vessel we steer through uncharted emotional and ethical waters, often resulting in profound self-discoveries.

Just as actors immerse themselves in roles, drawing upon their own emotional reserves to lend authenticity to their characters, so too do roleplayers invest themselves in the personas they assume. When navigating scenarios from epic fantasy quests to intense psychological dramas, these characters offer a safe space to grapple with decisions and consequences in a heightened, yet controlled, environment. This is storytelling as a lived experience where our choices echo not just in the world of the game but in the chambers of our own hearts.

The act of embodying a character in genres ranging from high fantasy to gritty horror or mind-bending psychological tales offers a unique platform for ethical and moral exploration. You're not just observing a rogue making a life-altering choice—you are that rogue. The weight of the decision sits squarely on your shoulders, pressing you to engage with complexities you might never confront otherwise. Ever wondered how you'd react if forced

to choose between the lesser of two evils? How about the greater of two evils? Roleplaying gives you a laboratory in which to experiment with those moral quandaries, examining them from every angle.

But perhaps the most fascinating aspect is the element of self-discovery. Stepping into another's shoes, even fictitiously, has a way of revealing the curves and contours of our own souls. It uncovers biases, fears, latent desires, and unspoken truths. As we walk the winding path of someone else's life, we inadvertently map out new corridors in our own inner landscapes, making for an enriching, introspective journey for those brave enough to let go and dive in.

Interactivity and Emotional Investment

In traditional storytelling, the audience largely receives the tale passively. They may engage emotionally or intellectually, but they don't participate in or influence the course of the narrative. Roleplaying games revolutionize this dynamic by making storytelling a collective art, a shared saga woven from the choices of each participant. The game master might lay out the canvas, but it's the players who fill it with life, with every decision branching the narrative into countless possible directions.

Choices and consequences are the building blocks of these multi-layered narratives. In a book or film, we might yell at a character for making what we perceive as the “wrong” choice, but in roleplaying, we are the architects of our own triumphs and downfalls—with some occasional input from the dice, of course. The stakes are often visceral, almost tangible. The ripple effect of every choice can lead to numerous outcomes, each more elaborate and nuanced than the last. This interactivity enriches the story, giving it dimensions that even the most intricate novels or films can seldom match.

The emotional investment players pour into the game amplifies in tandem with the weight of their choices. As you navigate your character through betrayals, moral dilemmas, and epic showdowns, an emotional bond forms not just with your own character, but with your companions, NPCs, and even antagonists. You root for them, you fear for them, and most remarkably, you understand them on a profound level, because you've “lived” through these experiences together. This emotional attachment transcends the game itself, leaving a transformative impact that lasts long after the dice have stopped rolling.

Immersion and Personalization

The term “immersion” frequently arises in conversations about roleplaying, and for good reason. Immersion represents that seamless melding of player and character, reality and fiction, where the lines blur and the game world feels as authentic as our own. Different genres offer unique avenues for this experience. In a horror roleplaying game, immersion might manifest in the creeping dread you feel as you navigate a haunted mansion. In a psychological story, it could be the unraveling of complex motivations or the exploration of ethical quandaries that make you question your very core beliefs.

Roleplaying isn’t just storytelling; it’s personalized, experiential storytelling. Unlike a novel or film where the story is set in stone, here, each participant acts as a co-author, influencing the plot, the world, and its inhabitants in real-time. Your character’s actions and inactions, their motivations, even their inner turmoil can steer the story in unexpected directions, providing an organic narrative uniquely tailored to the collective decisions and emotional beats of the people involved.

The most extraordinary aspect is that, when done properly, roleplaying democratically engages everyone in this storytelling process. Whether you’re a grizzled veteran GM or a first-timer who’s never rolled a D20, your voice matters. Each character’s arc contributes to the tapestry of the overarching narrative, and no one’s story is deemed less important. In doing so, roleplaying becomes a collective experience offering a sense of ownership and personalization that is unmatched in any other storytelling medium.

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The beginnings of storytelling may reside in ancient campfires and hieroglyphics, but its future is being written at tabletops, on digital platforms, and in the imaginations of roleplayers. Indeed, roleplaying stands as a medium that reveres the “sacred trust” of storytelling, offering an intimate, interactive space where listeners are also storytellers and vice versa.

In doing so, roleplaying brings unique enhancements to the age-old tradition of narrative sharing—each an amplification of the storytelling experience. It delves into varying genres, broadening the scope of themes and emotions we can explore. It elevates storytelling from a monologue to a dialogue, through choices and consequences that render the narrative richly layered and emotionally resonant. It magnifies immersion, allowing

us to put on the masks of our characters and engage with worlds that become real in our inner worlds. And, most impressively, it grants each participant the pen to personalize the story, democratizing the act of storytelling in the truest sense.

As we consider the untapped potential of roleplaying, one thing becomes clear: this medium isn't merely a vessel for escapism or entertainment. It's a burgeoning frontier where we can expand not only our understanding of storytelling but also the depths of our own human experience.

THREADING IN:

Asserting and Advocating for Your Characters Without Blasting Your Whole Damn Game to Smithereens

Scott Lynch

I'm not here to tell you about speech patterns or acting or improvisation or deep character psychology—I'm here to tell you about Dante, the most worthless goof of a character I ever talked myself into playing.

The Least Likely Worst Vampire of All Time

About twenty years ago I was forced to retire a live-action *Vampire: The Masquerade* character I'd invested considerable time in, and the replacement character I cooked up for my return to that game was a deranged act of vengeance.

I didn't consciously think so at the time, of course.

My previous character had been a paternal, overbearing, humorless jackass. A complete change of direction was obviously called for, so I fashioned the new guy as an irreverent, immature jackass. The previous character had been deeply involved in the politics and traditions of the vampire hierarchy. His biography had been elaborate. The new guy was footloose, unconnected. His background story was bullet points and all the bullet points would have fit on the inner side of my raised middle finger.

His name was Dante Bellicosa, and he was a science fiction rock opera impresario supposedly hard at work on a stage musical version of Robert Heinlein's *Starship Troopers*. His costume consisted of a white t-shirt with his name scrawled on it in black Sharpie marker—in part because I had no money at all, but also because Dante was a chintzy goon.

I wish I could say more about him, but he started at chintzy goon and went nowhere better. He was pure narrative vandalism. His purpose was to wander around breaking the fourth wall, making up songs and imaginary works-in-progress that were based entirely on in-jokes or internet memes, things no self-respecting centuries-old vampire might know about. His jokes were specifically meant to make twenty-something nerds giggle or crack up. I wasn't roleplaying, I was bypassing the possibility of roleplaying, taking everything and everyone out of character, pulling down the already precarious sense of atmosphere some of the players around me were still trying to sustain.

Dante wasn't me being amusingly eccentric—he was me pitching a fit, striking out at the fabric of the game, presuming that since I felt frustrated and exhausted everyone else must feel that way, too. I played him just twice before I realized what I was doing, at which point I quietly left the game and retired Dante to some perpetual Off-Off-Broadway workshop circuit of the damned.

However, I never really stopped thinking about him and how he fit into the schema of players attempting to torpedo a game experience for everyone around them.

Roleplaying offers myriad opportunities to launch such torpedoes, consciously or otherwise. Players certainly lash out selfishly and reflexively, as I did. They may also be plain and simple jerks, in which case there is precious little to be done here—if someone has the temperament of a game-wrecker for the sake of private amusement then no mere essay has the power to chase them back to the straight and narrow.

What we ought to talk about, however, is when players might feel adequately empowered by their character motivations (be they political ideals, religions, philosophies, or simple desires) to deliberately bring events to a screeching halt for everyone. Roleplaying, after all, involves advancing a set of fictional goals as measured by a set of fictional beliefs, so players and GMs alike should entertain at least the hypothetical possibility that those beliefs could fuel extreme actions. Real end-of-the-world type stuff, or even worse, end-of-the-gaming-group type stuff.

Hobby Gaming, Red in Tooth and Claw

Countless games over the years have made oppositional behavior a cornerstone of their play experience. Law opposes Chaos, Good opposes Evil, freedom opposes tyranny, werewolves oppose vampires, bards oppose a good night's rest. Factions and species and ideas whirl in competitions that can range from subtle to stark. In the 1980s, the original *Unearthed Arcana* supplement for *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons* introduced a barbarian class that could not “associate” with magic users and distrusted them even to the point of probable violence; these taboos could only be gradually shed as the barbarian gained experience levels. Until then, presumably, the adventurers in the party just had to watch their backs. In the 1990s, gamers across the globe were drawn into games of supernatural hyper-Machiavellian intrigue in which characters could be ground down in less time than it had taken to create them—I was one of those players! Even discounting structural incitements to bloody confrontations, players will supply a million more personal reasons to cross purposes with other players, with NPCs, with the GM, and even with the premise of the game itself.

Over the years I've seen too many players arrive at the end of such a conflict with their characters mashed like warm potatoes and their personal satisfaction with the game mashed twice as hard.

Now, it's not easy to lose a character or be foiled in one's plans and feel a resounding sense of satisfaction anyway. It's not easy to foil someone else's plans and help deliver a sense of satisfaction. Not easy . . . but I have to believe that for players who are already reflecting relatively deeply on their character motivations, just a touch of additional reflection can yield a significantly smoother experience for every participant. Fewer games exploded, fewer characters trampled in the chaos, fewer friendships strained. I've been analyzing and constructing my little method for some time now, and I call it “threading in.”

Asimov's Laws of Not Getting Dice Thrown at Your Head

The last few decades have seen the rise of the notion that above and beyond any individual character achievement in a game, a crucial thing is to somehow arrive at a Story (debate about this goes on and will go on until the sun is a cold exhausted soup). In many fantasy games this is handled as a twist on the traditional idea that individual stories will naturally cohere to form an epic tale. In other games, that coherence is more formalized. White Wolf games, for example, famously popularized the term “Storyteller” in lieu of “GM” or “referee.” I suspect that many of us who were heavily influenced by White Wolf in our early gaming years came away with an

unfairly negative connotation of that term—the idea that “storytelling” was primarily a prescriptive or authoritarian practice that enfolded the characters regardless of player input. It doesn’t need to be, of course. As a gamer and a fiction writer, I feel pretty confident in telling you that Story is inevitable. It’s whatever you arrive at, whether or not you were pushed toward a destination. You get there when you get there, and anyone’s influence on the course of it can be hugely positive or hugely negative. That’s why I think of “threading in” as such an essential concept.

Emotions rise when we roleplay; adrenaline flows, viewpoints constrict. Treasures might be laid out before us—why not seize them? Our religious opposition might start an argument—why not smite them? A throne might be empty—why not claim it with bloody hands? Those heathens in [A Different Faction] might foolishly think they can just exist peacefully in our vicinity—why not get rid of them forever?

Well, I’ve already hinted at so many reasons why: angry players, angry GMs, prematurely curtailed games, broken friendships, lost opportunities.

“Threading in” basically means cultivating the habit of voluntarily de-maximalizing your character’s response to the opportunities the game presents. Stay on task, certainly, and pursue your character’s appropriate goals, but rather than slamming face-first into all the various schemes and desires of the other participants, rather than escalating immediately to full engagement, full pursuit, full grasping covetous let-slip-the-dogs-of-war bloodshed, imagine threading your character’s plotline into the tapestry of everyone else’s with at least a hint of deliberate generosity.

The idea behind “threading in” is to stay in-character by pushing your own agenda as far as possible until you believe (or directly observe) that it might start to wreck someone else’s game experience, and at that point, hotshot, you cool your jets. A carelessly, selfishly played barbarian in that archaic style described above can’t abide the presence of magic-users . . . too bad if your friend at the end of the table has been playing one for five months! Ambush them, rend them, take their enchanted items and smash them to bits! Drive them from the party or kill them outright! You’re just playing your character, right? Your friend can’t blame you! You’re helpless to contravene the ancient customs of roleplaying!

What a sad, self-absorbed, narcissistic way to look at a cooperative hobby.

A “threaded-in” barbarian, given the same general beliefs and restrictions, would have no need to cause such a drastic change to the game and force one or more character sheets to be torn up immediately. Imagine the ways one might push the tension and hostility for lasting roleplaying amusement rather than instant theft or homicide—imagine jokes, taunts, pranks, and verbal arguments. Imagine refusing little courtesies, sleeping on opposite

sides of the camp, insisting on never being adjacent to one another in the party order. “Threading in” doesn’t mean meekly surrendering to every other player at the table. It simply means acknowledging the value of the game to every participant and taking a bit of care not to unilaterally smash things. Opposition, even bitter opposition, can continue—but you accept the responsibility of finding plausible reasons not to immediately push every lever into the flashing red danger zone.

I have a little set of guidelines, which I compare to Isaac Asimov’s Laws of Robotics, except not as clear and not as strict and absolutely not designed to prevent anyone from being murdered by an intelligent machine. What they are, though, is a helpful little thought exercise and checklist for the fine art of trying to keep narrative plates spinning as long as possible. Astute readers will also note that the guidelines will use words like “avoid” and “if” rather than any more strict formulation because, after all, we are talking about voluntary techniques of etiquette, not the iron laws of a secret cult. Without further ado:

1. Avoid Ending a Game Strictly for Your Own Character’s Purposes.

Probably the most crucial concept in “threading-in” is *just because you can, doesn’t mean you should*. Back when I played seemingly endless years of *Vampire: The Masquerade*, it was routine for at least one character in every single game (every single one!) to carry around a suitcase full of dynamite or some other form of explosive contraption for the purpose of forcing a stand-off with the higher powers of the game in the event they were threatened or foiled or even mildly inconvenienced. Any competent GM should be able to tell that sort of player “No, you can’t take the entire game and the efforts of dozens of people hostage on a whim. I don’t care if you downloaded an Anarchist’s Cookbook and drew a diagram—you can’t do it because this is still just a game and it’s a jerk-ass thing to do!” Any sufficiently mature player shouldn’t even need to have a GM tell them that. People who want to keep playing poker shouldn’t flip the table just because they caught a bad beat.

2. Avoid Destroying or Otherwise Permanently Changing the Status of Someone Else’s Character.

This is not to say that you can’t plot devious things for or against other characters, merely that, whenever possible, you should not throw someone else’s hard work and focal point for the game onto a fire without their consent and participation. “Don’t blow up the whole world” is macrocosm; “don’t blow up the buddy to your left or the buddy to your right” is microcosm.

3. If You Can Extend Warnings or Signal Your Intentions Before Making a Loud Noise, Do so.

Accept, also, that “if” is doing some heavy lifting here. Part of the pleasure of roleplaying, however, is that barring the need for full-on subterfuge, nobody you’re playing with should be confused by your character’s values and boundaries. Threading your story into the stories of others doesn’t necessitate a posture of victimization. While you’re trying to judge how not to wreck the game for everyone else, you should be actively providing hints to everyone else so they can do the same for you.

4. Proportional Self-Defense Is Always Appropriate and Opponents Who Invite a Smackin’ May Well Expect to Get It.

“Threading in” isn’t about the absolute avoidance of conflict and hard conclusions—it’s a set of tactics for pushing such hard conclusions off as long as possible so that everyone can better enjoy the ride. Still, the time usually comes when decisive conflict can no longer be postponed. Literally or figuratively, you’ll probably have to step out onto a dusty street and make ready to draw your six-shooter against a quick-handed opponent. In such moments, everything will run so much more smoothly and the game will play out so much more satisfyingly if everyone involved understands the stakes, accepts the challenge, and is prepared to take the consequences.

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That’s really all there is to it. Be assertive and claim your space, but do it without inflexible and thoughtless aggression toward the stuff the other players happen to be enjoying. No more fratricidal barbarians, no more suitcase bombs, no more Dante Bellicosas!

ALWAYS CLIMB ONTO THE DRAGON:

Embracing the Fantasy of TTRPGs

Robert Mason (Bob World Builder)

Still dripping with black, sulfuric sludge from two days mucking through the marshlands of Brelain, this weary magician—without any spells left to speak of—casts their grappling hook up, over, and successfully around the dragon’s neck. The majestic mirror-scaled monster had slaughtered almost two dozen villagers in only the last few days, and the novice adventurer joined a mob of others who dared to stop it. With the battle looking grim, they had to try something.

People play tabletop roleplaying games for many different reasons. Some want to enjoy a game night with friends, family, or strangers (who often quickly become friends). Some want to explore open worlds beyond the mountain peaks (or high fences) that block our passage in video games. Some, who will find this book particularly useful, want to fill the shoes of a different person with their own way of thinking, speaking, and behaving. But this author believes there is one overriding reason we choose to play RPGs with specific themes of adventure and fantasy: We want to face dangerous situations with unshakable courage like the heroes we have read about since childhood. That desire to stand up for what is right despite the dangers of doing so is *the* fantasy we aim for as players and must prepare for as game masters.

The italicized scene above describes one moment where I, playing a level-less and class-less randomly generated “hero” with gear such as a grappling hook—and, notably, a “large sponge”—decided to fully embrace the fantasy during an impromptu one-shot. My own snap decision to climb the dragon made me realize that, as a player character, I always climb onto huge monsters when I get the chance. Thankfully, I almost always play with game masters who are excited—or at least willing—to entertain the improbable. From their tables, to mine, to yours, the following principles should help you to actualize this type of daring fantasy action during your game sessions.

Think back on the first session where you felt the thrill that hooked you on these sorts of games. What was your character like? Who were their allies? As a player or game master, what challenges did the party face, and, most importantly, how did they face them? As beginners, our grasp on the rules is loose at best. Therefore, our choices are based not on what we know we can do within the confines of the rules, but rather on what we truly want our characters to do as inspired by the courageous adventurers of our favorite stories.

- “I want to spin around and strike them all with my sword!”
- “I want to shoot an arrow through its wing!”
- “I want to use my lightning spell to shock the water!”

In modern editions of the most famous fantasy roleplaying game, the official answers to those questions are essentially “no, no, and no.” Rules are necessary to provide structure and consistency, but highly specific rules tend to get in the way of player choice.

- “No, your character class can only make one attack per turn at this level unless you choose this subclass/feat/etc.”
- “No, because if you can shoot a monster in the wing, then the monsters would be able to maim your character too.”
- “No, magic doesn’t work like that, or it would be too powerful.”

With this restrictive approach to game mastering, open-minded beginners either stop playing the game, stop attempting imaginative maneuvers, learn the rules well enough to use a limited number of powerful actions, or learn the rules with such scrutiny that they find overpowered options the game’s designers missed. As game masters, we have a responsibility to favor the fantasy over the written rule.

A simple, “Well, you can try, but you’ll need a high roll” is often all that is necessary to please your players and uphold the structure of the game. For this very reason, game masters used to be called referees or judges, arbitrating rulings for the infinite options available to the players that could

never be prescribed in any one core rulebook . . . or even three. Sometimes, these off-book rolls can rely on critical successes, on an existing character statistic, or even on a “luck” stat if your system of choice has one. Otherwise, rolling a six-sided die is a fine substitute: 1–3 = in the players’ favor, 4–6 = not in the players’ favor—or you can tilt the odds one way or the other to match the situation. And as players, it is our simple duty to maintain the beginner’s mindset, thinking of the fantastic options available to us that can be enhanced by our character sheet, not limited by it, and trusting our game masters’ rulings.

Then, when relying on one’s instinctual motivation to attempt daring feats, we must also consider how to involve our adventuring companions. Popular fantasy roleplaying games often claim to be designed to facilitate collaborative storytelling, but the end products appear better suited to enable individual power fantasy escapism. While it is fun to create and imagine a lone fantasy hero standing against great evils, it is only through facing their own demons that heroes become legends, and it is only through collaboration with allies that heroes can complement and accept each other’s shortcomings.

Keeping in mind the greatest evils must be faced by the whole party helps us avoid the biggest pitfall of including pulp adventure moments in our game sessions. For example, when my grappling hook-wielding magician scrambled onto the iridescent dragon, the goal in part was to help another player character already in its jaws, because that PC had charged boldly into this impossible fight hoping to inspire the rest of the party. That other player grabbed the spotlight, had their moment, then poised themselves to shine it on whomever stepped up next. I followed suit, distracting the dragon with my own stunt. Then more PCs worked together and managed to trap the monster in a magical column of light before it took to the skies . . . but we’ll finish that story later. The spotlight must shine on one hero, then move to another, then another, and so on.

Depending on the particular story unfolding, yes, perhaps one session should devote a great deal of attention to one character, but then the campaign must offer the same opportunity to every other player who would enjoy that attention. Most often, the easiest approach for the game master is to pace each game session such that each character has their own time to shine. These moments in the spotlight can be amplified by encouraging the star player to add to the resulting description or to take hold of the scene and describe their own character’s epic deed in detail. In that case, it is up to the player, or the game master if the player holds too tightly, to know when to move the camera. Ideally, this progression gives the next player something to *yes-and*—something to latch onto and push the excitement a little further or into a new direction.

As alluded to in my dragon story, this progression from one character to the next is both fluid and epic during deeds of self-sacrifice. Consider one of the most memorable and well-known moments in fantasy fiction: The Grey Pilgrim Gandalf proclaims, “I am a servant of the Secret Fire, wielder of the flame of Anor.” Then his voice echoes over the bridge of Khazad-Dûm, “You shall not pass!” (or “You cannot pass!” for source material devotees.) The Balrog fell into the abyss, then so went the wizard. A climax to be sure—the excitement was not pushed further by the next scene, but, rather, one character was able to simultaneously create a timeless image of heroism and motivate their companions to become greater heroes in the days to come, all through sacrifice. Note that although modern fantasy roleplaying games often include rules for miraculous resurrection similar to Gandalf’s return, this author is not recommending every in-game sacrifice be quite so fatal. That would make for quick campaigns or merely steal all meaning and significance from death itself. The key lesson is to remember that sacrifice is the true essence of heroism, and tiny sacrifices can be just as potent for creating memorable moments among your party.

Setting the intention to build one “tiny sacrifice” into your character’s turn is, in my experience, the best way to seed moments of epic fantasy as a player. As a game master, I encourage this altruistic behavior by awarding physical “hero coins” that the players can later turn in to boost their own rolls or an ally’s rolls, similar to the inspiration mechanic in popular fantasy TTRPGs.

Finally, in my story, when the rest of the party realized that smashing the magical mirror they found in the dragon’s lair could kill it in midair, they did, and it fell, then so went my magician. Unexpectedly, I rolled a critical success and the character narrowly survived, so I proclaimed they were saved by landing on their other random piece of gear: a large sponge. Being a randomly rolled character and a generally comedic atmosphere, we were all able to get a laugh out of this character’s near-death experience while staying in line with that one-shot’s tone.

Indulging the fantasy is about enhancing the narrative of your group’s games, not disrupting it. It’s about sharing the spotlight, tiny or mortal sacrifices, fostering the beginner mindset, and always, *always* climbing onto the dragon.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTORS

JOHN JOSEPH ADAMS is the series editor of Best American Science Fiction and Fantasy and is the editor of more than forty anthologies, such as *Wastelands*, *The Living Dead*, *Epic: Legends of Fantasy*, *The Way of the Wizard*, *Operation Arcana*, and *Lost Worlds & Mythological Kingdoms*. His most recent book is *Out There Screaming*, which he co-edited with Jordan Peele. He is also editor (and publisher) of the Hugo Award-winning magazine *Lightspeed* and is publisher of its sister-magazine *Nightmare*. In addition to his short fiction work, he's a producer for WIRED's *The Geek's Guide to the Galaxy* podcast, and for five years he was the editor of the John Joseph Adams Books novel imprint for Houghton Mifflin Harcourt where he edited novels by authors such as Veronica Roth, Hugh Howey, Greg Bear, Carrie Vaughn, Ashok K. Banker, and others. Lately, he's also been working as an editor on various TTRPG projects for Kobold Press and Monte Cook Games, as a contributing game designer on books such as Kobold Press's *Tome of Heroes*. Learn more at johnjosephadams.com and johnjosephadams.com/rpg.

KEITH AMMANN is the author of the ENnie-winning blog and book *The Monsters Know What They're Doing* and the more recently published *MOAR! Monsters Know What They're Doing* and *How to Defend Your Lair*. He has been a tabletop roleplaying gamer and game master for more than thirty years. He lives in Chicago (physically) and at spyandowl.com and @KeithAmmann@dice.camp (virtually).

SHARANG BISWAS has won two IGDN awards, three Ennie Awards, an IndieCade award, and a Golden Cobra award for roleplaying games. He has showcased interactive works at institutions such as The Institute of Contemporary Art in Philadelphia, Pioneer Works in Brooklyn, and The Museum of the Moving Image in Queens. He has written for games such as *Avatar: Legends*, *Spire: The City Must Fall*, *Moonlight on Roseville Beach*, *Jiangshi: Blood on the Banquet Hall*, and *Dungeons & Dragons Live*. His fiction and poetry have appeared in *Lightspeed Magazine*, *Fantasy Magazine*, *Strange Horizons*, and more, while his story "Sutekh: A Breath Of Spring" was selected for Neon Hemlock Press's *We're Here: The Best Queer Speculative Fiction 2021*. He is also the co-editor of *Honey & Hot Wax: An Anthology of Erotic Art Games* (Pelgrane Press).

BRYAN CAMP is a graduate of the Clarion West Writers Workshop and the University of New Orleans' Low-Residency MFA program. He started writing his first novel, *The City of Lost Fortunes*, in the backseat of his parents' car as they evacuated for Hurricane Katrina. He has been, at various points in his life: a security guard at a stockcar racetrack, a printer in a flag factory, an office worker in an oil refinery, and a high school English teacher. He can be found at bryancamp.com and on Bluesky @[bryancamp.bsky.social](https://bsky.app/profile/bryancamp.bsky.social). He lives in New Orleans with his wife and their cats, one of whom is named after a superhero.

CHRISTOPHER M. CEVASCO writes historical fiction, speculative fiction, and horror. His debut novel, *Beheld: Godiva's Story* (Lethe Press), was released in April 2022, and his short stories have appeared in such venues as *Beneath Ceaseless Skies*, *Black Static*, and *Shades of Blue and Gray: Ghosts of the Civil War* (Prime Books). Chris creates bestselling D&D content available through DMsGuild, including such titles as *Fellozial's Ultimate Guide to Poison*, *The Primal Gith*, *Bound to Avernus*, and *Heorot: Beowulf's Domain of Dread*. He was also a contributing designer for Kobold Press's *Tome of Heroes* (2022) and a contributing author for the *Kobold Guide to Dungeons* (2023). After ten years in Brooklyn, NY, Chris and his wife moved to Myrtle Beach, SC, where they've lived for more than a decade with their two children. Find him online at christophermcevasco.com.

CURTIS C. CHEN is a former Silicon Valley software engineer who now writes stories and runs puzzle games near Portland, Oregon. He's the author of the Kangaroo series of funny science fiction spy thrillers and wrote for the Realm original podcasts *Echo Park*, *Ninth Step Murders*, and *Machina*. Curtis' short fiction has appeared in *Playboy Magazine*, *Aliens vs. Predators: Ultimate Prey*, *The Sunday Morning Transport*, and elsewhere. His homebrew cat feeding robot was displayed in the "Worlds Beyond Here" exhibit at Seattle's Wing Luke Museum. Visit him online at CurtisCChen.com.

GINNY DI is a Denver-based game writer and YouTuber who uses costumes and immersive character acting to advise half a million followers on how to improve their dungeon master skills, deepen their character building, and strengthen their roleplay. She has authored fifth edition adventures like "Bard Behind Bars," "Flesh and Blood," and "The Cold and Hungry Sea," as well as two years of monthly D&D supplements for her Patreon supporters. Her writing has been featured in Steamforged Games' *Bardsung* and *Animal Adventures: The Faraway Sea*, Roll For Combat's *Battlezoo Ancestries: Dragons*, and Jeff Stevens Games' *Potbellied Kobold's Guide to Villains and Lairs*. Find her online at ginnydi.com.

SHANNA GERMAIN is an award-winning writer, editor, and game designer, as well as the co-founder of Monte Cook Games. Her body of work encompasses stories, games, novels, poems, and essays. Recent game projects include *The Old Gods of Appalachia Roleplaying Game*, *The Devil's Dandy Dogs*, *We Are All Mad Here*, and *Predation*. Her fiction has appeared or is forthcoming in places like *Apex Magazine*, *The Deadlands*, *Fantasy Magazine*, *Lightspeed Magazine*, *The Sun*, and more. She lives in a rainforest with a dog named &. Follow her down the rabbit hole at shannagermain.com.

BASHEER GHOUSE is a writer, game designer, and cultural consultant based out of San Jose, California. He's worked on projects for Kobold Press, Rowan Rook and Deckard, Paizo, Critical Role, Wizards of the Coast, and more. He's currently working on his first major independent game, *Guns Blazing!*

LUKE GYGAX is an author, game designer, and the son of *Dungeons & Dragons* creator Gary Gygax. He literally grew up at the gaming table playtesting games and adventure scenarios with his father, contributing concepts and content in the process. His credits include *Legion of Gold*, *The Lost City of Gaxmoor*, *The Dread From Geneva Lake*, as well as several scenarios in his fantasy world setting, *The World of Okkorim*. He is the founder of Gary Con, a memorial convention held in honor of his father every March in Lake Geneva, WI. Luke retired from the United States Army after more than 30 years of service in September 2022. He lives in Southern California with his beautiful wife, Bouchra, and their three daughters, Miriam, Amira, and Sabrina.

LUKE HART'S journey with medieval fantasy began in middle school when his mother bought him *Streams of Silver* by R.A. Salvatore. Then it bled over into roleplaying games when his grandmother bought him the core rule books for *Dungeons & Dragons* second edition while he was in high school. Since then, he's played tabletop RPGs in person with friends, online with other RPG enthusiasts, and via play-by-post while serving in Central America as a missionary. These days Luke and his team run The DM Lair where they produce GM advice videos and GM resources such as *Lair Magazine*. Luke, of course, also runs several tabletop RPG games.

SHAREEF JACKSON is a STEM diversity advocate, educator, and gaming professional. His culturally relevant communication style helps break down science, gaming, and math in a way that the average person can understand and appreciate. Shareef currently teaches math at New Jersey Institute of

Technology and Rutgers University Newark, and he tutors via his company Math Looks Good LLC. He was a player on *Rivals of Waterdeep*, an actual play D&D show, as well as the GM of the *Kids on Bikes* show *Trouble in Techburg*. Shareef's online home is shareefjackson.com, and he goes by ShareefJackson on all social networks.

RAJAN KHANNA is a writer, game designer, and musician who lives in Philadelphia surrounded by cats and guitars. His three novels, *Falling Sky*, *Rising Tide*, and *Raining Fire*, take place in a post-apocalyptic world of airships and floating cities. His short fiction has appeared in *Analog*, *Asimov's*, *Beneath Ceaseless Skies*, *Clarkesworld*, *Fantasy*, *Lightspeed*, and multiple anthologies. His articles, reviews, and commentary have appeared on *Tor.com*, *LitReactor*, and *The Geek's Guide to the Galaxy*. His game design work can be found in several Kobold Press products including the *Tome of Heroes*, Vol. 2 of the *Kobold Guide to Worldbuilding*, the *Kobold Guide to Dungeons*, *Wastes of Chaos*, *Deep Magic 2*, and several *Tales of the Valiant* products. His personal website is rajankhanna.com.

CHRIS KLUWE is the author of sci-fi novel *Otaku* and the short story and essay collection *Beautifully Unique Sparkleponies* and is the lead designer and creator of the tabletop card game *Twilight of the Gods*. Born and raised by a wild pack of chinchillas in Southern California, he also played eight years in the NFL for the Minnesota Vikings, setting numerous team records, once wrestled a bear for a pot of gold, and has been known to lie occasionally in author biographies. You can find him on BlueSky @ChrisWarcraft.

SCOTT LYNCH was born in St. Paul, Minnesota in 1978, the first of three brothers. Early in life he worked as a dishwasher, a waiter, a graphic designer, an office manager, a cook, and a game supplement self-publisher before accidentally selling his first novel, *The Lies of Locke Lamora*, in 2004. From 2005 to 2016 Scott also served as a paid-on-call firefighter in St. Croix County, Wisconsin. Scott currently lives in Massachusetts with his wife, award-winning SF/F novelist Elizabeth Bear, along with three cats (Duncan, Gurney, and Molly) and a moderately ridiculous horse (an Icelandic gelding named Ormr).

ROBERT MASON (BOB WORLD BUILDER) is a writer and worldbuilding enthusiast with a YouTube channel. He makes videos about GM and player advice, game reviews and news, and fun TTRPG rules and mechanics . . . sometimes even testing those rules in real life. Bob has also published numerous 5e one-shot adventures, has written for Goodman Games, Media Lab Books, Kobold Press, and others, and he co-hosts an

RPG podcast called *It's What Our Characters Would Do* with his wife Grace (World Destroyer). You can follow his work on Patreon and YouTube @BobWorldBuilder.

CLINT MCELROY is a 45-year veteran of broadcasting who now works on the popular podcast *The Adventure Zone* with his sons Justin, Travis, and Griffin. He is the author of the picture book *Goldie's Guide to Grandchilding* with co-author Eliza Kinkz, one of the co-writers of *The Adventure Zone* graphic novels, along with *War of the Realms: Journey Into Mystery*, for Marvel Comics, and *Marvel Team-Up*. He's currently working on an animated *The Adventure Zone* TV show for NBC's Peacock streaming service. He has three BEST DAD coffee mugs and six BEST GRANDPA . . . although the titles have been challenged.

ERIN ROBERTS is a writer of stories and games whose game writing has appeared in projects including Nebula finalist and silver ENnie winner *Journeys through the Radiant Citadel*, *Hunter: The Reckoning*, *Lost Omens: Highhelm*, and *Starfinder Interstellar Species*. Her prose and interactive fiction have been published in *Asimov's*, *Clarkesworld*, *Strange Horizons*, and *The Dark*, among other venues, and selected for three Year's Best collections. Erin is a Provost's Early Career Fellow at the University of Texas at Austin, where she teaches creative writing, a co-host of the award-winning Writing Excuses podcast, and a 2023 Diana Jones Award Emerging Designer Program Winner. You can find the latest links to her writing and other escapades at linktr.ee/erinroberts.

MICHAEL E. SHEA is the writer for the website Sly Flourish and the author of *Return of the Lazy Dungeon Master*, *The Lazy DM's Workbook*, *The Lazy DM's Companion*, *Fantastic Adventures: Ruins of the Grendleroot*, and co-author of *Fantastic Lairs* and *Forge of Foes*. Mike has worked with a bunch of RPG companies including Wizards of the Coast, Kobold Press, Pelgrane Press, and MCDM. Mike's been playing RPGs since the mid '80s and writing for and about RPGs since 2008. Mike is also the son of Robert J. Shea, author of the '70s cult science fiction novel *Illuminatus!* (yes, the exclamation point is actually part of the title). Mike lives with his wife Michelle in Northern Virginia, USA.

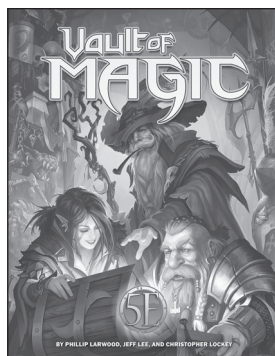
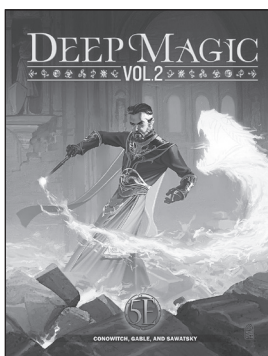
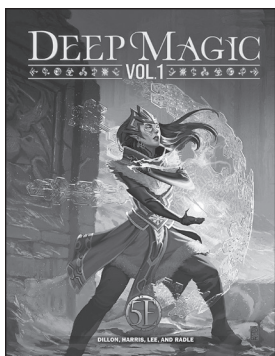
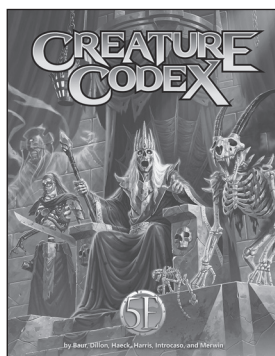
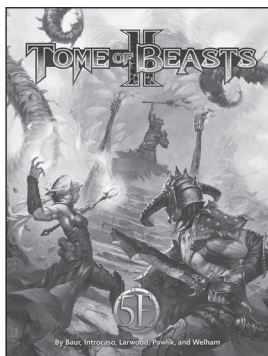
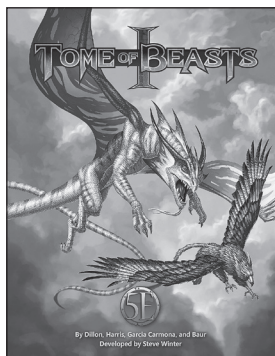
GAIL SIMONE is a critically acclaimed writer of comics and animation, having written landmark runs on such titles as *Deadpool*, *Birds of Prey*, *Batgirl*, *Wonder Woman*, and many more. She's also written for animated series including *Tomb Raider*, *My Little Pony*, *Brave and the Bold*, and *Justice League Unlimited*. She is a fierce advocate for new voices in genre fiction and lives on the Oregon coast with her family and greyhound.

SAGE STAFFORD is a professional tabletop content creator, writer, and audio editor, and they are the creative director of the award-winning podcast and stream: *Venture Maidens*. To commission them to write, consult, or run a game, find them @StaffOfSage on Twitter.

WENDY N. WAGNER is the Locus award-nominated editor of *Nightmare Magazine* and the senior/managing editor of *Lightspeed Magazine*. Her short fiction, essays, and poetry have appeared in over seventy venues. She lives in Oregon with her very understanding family.

B. DAVE WALTERS is a prominent figure in the entertainment and writing sectors, with accomplishments in film, TV, comics, graphic novels, and novels. He is renowned for writing *Dungeons & Dragons: A Darkened Wish* for IDW comics and *Invitation to Party* on G4 TV. His notable contributions extend to family films such as *Lena & Snowball* and *The Pet Detectives*. Additionally, Walters co-authored *Devil's Brigade*, the *Salvage Marines* TV series, and the *Electropunk Transmedia* series. His extensive writing prowess encompasses tabletop role-playing games (TTRPGs), novels, non-fiction books, and over 500 nationally syndicated articles.

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